The World of the Gods Wouldn't Care for Us

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31963750.

Rating:	Mature
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	原神 | Genshin Impact (Video Game)
Relationship:	Jean/Lisa (Genshin Impact)
Characters:	Lisa (Genshin Impact), Jean (Genshin Impact), Razor (Genshin Impact), Fischl (Genshin Impact), Bennett (Genshin Impact), Mona (Genshin Impact), Kaeya (Genshin Impact), Venti (Genshin Impact), Paimon (Genshin Impact), Traveler (Genshin Impact), Amber (Genshin Impact), Noelle (Genshin Impact), Barbara (Genshin Impact), Albedo (Genshin Impact), Sucrose (Genshin Impact), Eula (Genshin Impact)
Additional Tags:	Inazuma (Genshin Impact), Angst with a Happy Ending, Gay Sex, Implied/Referenced Suicide, Near Death, Implied/Referenced Character Death
Language:	English
Collections:	jeanlisa week
Stats:	Published: 2021-06-20 Words: 27,737 Chapters: 4/4

The World of the Gods Wouldn't Care for Us

by Diaspro (IceRosesCrown)

Summary

An ambassador from Inazuma brings an odd request to Mondstadt's current authority, Acting Grand Master Jean, and everything spirals down since the Electro Archon won't play by the rules. Are the visions really simple tools, or are they a vital part of those who got them? Would the archons ever care for the consequences of their actions, when they affect mere mortals? Would the Archon of eternity spare a glance to look at the harm done to finite lives?

"It has always been like that, Jean; you can place your faith and trust on Barbatos, but the truth is... the world of the gods wouldn't care for us. They don't intend to."

Notes

Dedicated to Robin (misono), and special thanks to Lugh (Twitter: LughtheSunKing) for being the test lab rat for my first ever spice scene.

AU clarifications:
-This fic follows the idea of Archon Baal collecting visions but extends her will to every single electro vision outside Inazuma too.
-As this was originally a dream (nightmare?) some things make no general sense, but apply for logic's sake: Baal sent some ambassadors to collect electro visions from "estranged" wielders unless they can prove they still retain full citizenship, but will sever all electro visions connection to their wielders everywhere in Teyvat regardless. (That would be: she still won't let anyone have electro power, wants to recover the visions but will respect other archons' people, letting them keep the waned vision)
-The lore isn't clear about how the archons grant visions, if regardless of the element or not (maybe the element follow some set criteria while the archons just allow you to have it or not), but for this AU the archons grant visions of their element (all for angst's sake, sorry)
-Another note on "will sever all electro visions connection to their wielders everywhere in Teyvat": in the 1.6 ver trailer, we can hear Kazuha saying the vision's light fades when its wielder dies so, for this AU, Baal is able to cut off that connection while the wielders still live, but she's unaware of the side effects that's gonna have on the people; I guess you can imagine what part of the plot will be.
-A happier clarification: the dream included some kind of "old traditional proposal poem" or something like that, absolutely non-existant on the game, which I'll include cause it's really sweet.

Act 1: Estranged Citizen

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mondstadt, Favonius headquarters, evening:

The sun was almost setting when Acting Grand Master Jean called for an impromptu meeting. She had been informed about the arrival of an ambassador from Inazuma who requested an immediate audience with the Grand Master. It was undoubtedly a matter of great importance, yet almost every captain had been deployed recently and the ambassador seemed unwilling to wait until the next day, so Grand Master Jean called Captain Kaeya, who had been aware of the ambassador's movements since his arrival; miss Lisa, sure she could trust her judgment about anything the ambassador may have to say; and the honorary knight, who had been protecting Mondstadt as much as Jean herself.

Moments before he arrived at Jean's office, they exchanged opinions about the possible reasons for such a visit.

—I must say this is extremely rare from the Bakufu— Lisa commented. —Ambassadors aren't a rare sight in a land as extensive as Teyvat, but with Inazuma's current situation, this is most unexpected.

—Only unexpected?— Kaeya snorted. —News from Liyue say no one is allowed to leave Inazuma; if Raiden Shogun sent an ambassador there must be something she's very interested in.

—What could Mondstadt possibly have to make an Archon send her diplomat? This must be official business— Jean replied.

—Last we were in Liyue—, Paimon interrupted, —we were told about the restrictions the Electro archon set in Inazuma.

—No one can enter or leave without passing an assessment by the Kanjobugyo, only the Fatui come and go freely because of their diplomatic immunity— Lumine added.

—So convenient— Kaeya noticed.

—Well, now— Lisa interrupted, shifting her posture a little. —Let's not get ahead of ourselves, maybe this isn't a political matter at all.

—Then why...— Jean was about to ask, when someone knocked on the door. —Come in— she answered.

A man of average height and elegantly dressed opened the door, entered silently, and bowed before Jean after closing the door. The robe he's wearing is nothing like the clothing Lumine

has seen in either Mondstadt or Liyue, and he bears an emblem the three knights quickly recognized as the Inazuman Emblem.

—Good evening, Grand Master, and knights of Favonius— he greeted them. —I humbly thank you for conceding this meeting to me in such short notice.

—Good evening, Ambassador. I am Jean Gunnhildr, Acting Grand Master. In the name of the Knights of Favonius, we welcome you to Mondstadt— Jean replied. —We understand you must have come on important business if you requested an audience with such urgency.

He nodded, put both hands behind his back, and straightened his posture before speaking.

—The Inazuma Bakufu, lead by our illustrious Raiden Shogun, has sent me here to retrieve something from one of Mondstadt's residents. I would greatly appreciate your assistance and cooperation— he announced.

From opposite sides of the room, Kaeya and Lisa exchanged a suspicious glance which Jean perfectly noticed but willingly ignored.

—If you don't mind, Ambassador, may we know what your Bakufu needs from one of our citizens?— Jean asked, carefully phrasing her questions.

—Oh no, you misunderstand me, Grand Master. I wouldn't have been sent if it were a citizen — he quickly answered. Everyone's surprised reaction pushed him to quickly continue. — Please allow me to clarify. Our distinguished Raiden Shogun is on a mission to gather all the divine gifts in our territory, and has decided to extend her will to anyone in Teyvat who had been blessed with her own power— he began. Everyone looked at Lisa, who was suddenly pale, but he never noticed. Paimon seemed to be about to comment, but the ambassador had more to say. —However, she respects the other archons, and the citizens under their wing shall keep their godly gifts— he concluded.

It seemed like everyone in the room had been holding their breath until that moment. Lisa looked away from the ambassador only to notice both Jean and Kaeya were still looking at her, clearly concerned, and she slightly nodded.

Kaeya raised a hand to clear his throat and asked with a seemingly gentle tone —By "godly gifts", you mean the visions?

As the ambassador nodded, the knights felt more at ease. If it wasn't a citizen, could he possibly be speaking of Lumine? But she only wielded anemo and geo, and didn't even have a vision to be retrieved.

Noticing the silence, as everyone was deep in thought, Paimon shook her head and asked — But who in Mondstadt has an electro vision and is not a citizen?

Lumine looked at her; she could only think maybe it was Razor, but he had always resided in the territory and with Andrius looking after him, he should also be considered under Barbatos’ protection, right?

After Paimon's question, the ambassador began searching his apparel until he found a small black wooden box from where he extracted a tiny note and read it aloud.

—I was given the name Miss Lisa Minci— he declared.

Once again the room fell silent and everyone looked at Lisa, only this time the witch seemed more incredulous than scared. The ambassador looked up from his note and followed everyone's gaze only to find the librarian staring at him in such disbelief he felt as if he had accidentally insulted someone.

—Excuse me— she finally said. She took a deep breath and mustered all her strength to calmly ask —Didn't you just explain that citizens keep their visions?

—Absolutely. The electro user I'm looking for is considered to be estranged from Mondstadt, and also left Sumeru before she could be considered a citizen there. Currently resides here, but remains estranged, as I said before— he answered, oblivious of the impact of his words.

—Estranged...—Jean repeated before Lisa herself could find the words. —That makes no sense. She returned so long ago— she added.

—Unfortunately—, the ambassador interrupted, —having no roots to either Mondstadt or Sumeru, she’s not considered a citizen under the protection of any archon.

This made so little sense for the knights, and the ambassador was still so in the dark about the subject, they once again let a long silence install between them.

Finally, Lisa spoke up, deciding they couldn't simply pretend it was someone else.

—I beg your pardon, Ambassador, but I am a full Mondstadt citizen, I have a stable work and a home— she began, before feeling her lungs fully empty and losing her speech for a second. —I can't possibly give up my vision. I won't.

—And I won't allow it— Jean instantly stated, taking a few steps between Lisa and the ambassador.

—None of us will, Ambassador— Kaeya added. —You should go back and let your archon know that miss Lisa is a Mondstadt citizen.

—Yes! And she can always ask Lord Barbatos— Paimon added. —He will tell her Lisa is under his protection.

The ambassador remained silent, lowered his sight, and once again joined both hands behind his back.

With a serious, almost severe, tone, he pronounced —I am here to fulfill the will of the Inazuma Bakufu. I shall only return with her vision—, he looked directly at Lisa, —or legal proof or her citizenship.

—There’s no legal proof...— Lisa was already replying, when Jean turned around and interrupted her.

—There has to be something.

—I have no papers for the lab because it's way too ancient, and since I live with you, I don't have my own residence papers either— she continued. —I haven't been involved in legal processes at all, and managing the library isn't enough, or is it?

The ambassador shook his head in response.

—There has to be something— Jean insisted, almost frantic. —You're part of the Knights, right?

—I rejected the position as captain, so I was never granted knighthood by the church, meaning there are, again, no papers— she explained.

—Then...— Jean began.

—Then what?— Lisa asked, a tone of defeat tainting her voice.

—Then marry me.

—What!?— Lisa took a step back. This was not how things should happen. —No, Jean… you don't know what you're saying— she let out, taking another step away from her and towards the door; her expression unreadable. Noticing she would have to go through the ambassador to leave the office, she stopped and muttered —This is madness.

The next second, she disappeared in a blink.

Kaeya, Lumine, and Paimon stared at Jean's back, fearing what was about to happen but not daring to move, talk, or even breathe too deeply. Her lowered head was enough to let them know what her expression was, and when she closed her hands in fists, Kaeya looked at Lumine and signaled the door with a move of his head.

—Out— she said. —Everyone out, now!— she repeated, ordering this time, head raised but still not looking at them. Kaeya was already pushing Lumine through the door, barely opened, when she turned around and insisted —Out right now!

Her face wouldn't betray the pure rage she was feeling, it was a sober expression that convinced the ambassador to follow the captain out of the office.

Once the door was closed, Kaeya ordered a few knights on standby to accompany the ambassador to where he was staying and, fortunately, they left before Jean's yelling could be heard inside the headquarters.

Soon, Noelle had shown up, alerted by the noise.

—Ah, Noelle— Kaeya noticed. —Please, if you don't mind. Would you keep guard here?— he asked, behaving unusually gently. —No one should bother our Grand Master until she decides to leave the office. Under no circumstances allow anyone to disturb her. Can I trust you?

Noelle nodded decisively.

—Yes Captain. I won't let you down— she answered.

—Perfect— he said with a smile. When he turned back to Lumine, some of his distress was already back into his expression. —Can I ask you to help me look for our librarian, honorary knight?

She and Paimon nodded and the three left the headquarters.

Stormterror's lair, tower, night:

The strong currents surrounding the tower in Stormterror's lair felt cold, nearly violent, while the ominous stillness of the air within the tower felt almost warm. She could practically feel the energy emanating from the depths of the tower, a mystery that invited her to glide down and find its origin. And what exactly was stopping her now?

—I'd rather pursue your mystery than hand in my vision— she muttered, as if the depths could answer her.

Her voice reached higher in the tower where Venti had sat to stare at the landscape. When he noticed someone else was there, he quickly went down only to find Lisa standing on the edge, one hand opened towards the center of the tower. For a fraction of a second, he thought the worst, but there was something contemplative about her stance.

—Miss Lisa— he called. She looked back unamused, her expression was a mix of tiredness and absolute calmness. —I'm surprised to find you here— he continued, pretending to start a casual conversation. —But I'm certainly not surprised that you noticed this tower's peculiarity — he continued, finally drawing her attention.

She quickly understood what he meant and assured him —I have no intentions to uncover this truth just yet, please don't worry.

—I would never worry, you're a very capable woman— he replied. —I'm intrigued, however; what made you come here, if not this particularly alluring phenomenon?— he asked, trying to sound inconspicuous.

She fully turned to face him and crossed both arms in front of her chest.

—A little curious, aren't you?

Venti laughed nervously, considering whether to fully disclose the reasons for his question or stop pressing the matter.

—I… Alright, I can't fool you— he decided. —Something is clearly wrong, so if you allow me… may I lend you my ear to help you unload whatever is troubling you?— he asked, genuinely concerned.

A little taken aback by such honest offering, she took a deep breath before accepting.

—Well… We just had a curious visitor from Inazuma— she began, already surprising him. —An ambassador was sent by the Electro archon to collect the visions from electro users who are not "citizens" of other territories, and can't be considered under another archon's protection— she explained. —And apparently… I've been deemed "estranged" from Mondstadt— she pronounced with absolute disgust.

—You what?— Venti retorted, with a mix of shock and disbelief. —Excuse me, miss Lisa, how exactly are you not considered under Barbatos' protection?

She wanted to laugh at how he asked that, but a wave of sadness overcame her.

—My long time in Sumeru is apparently related to that. And since I came back, I haven't really done much to establish myself here— she explained, sight lowered, almost ashamed. —I suppose it looks like I could simply walk out of Mondstadt never to return, because it's like I have nothing keeping me here.

—But you have.

—Of course I have— she replied, almost instantly, looking at him for a brief moment. There was a fire in her eyes for a second before, once again, a defeated demeanor took over her expression. —But I can't prove it and… let's just say the worst possible scenario just happened.

—That is?

—Ugh… Maybe she was just freaking out, but—, she let out a sight, —Jean just proposed to me out of nowhere. And I can swear there's nothing I dread more than her just rushing a decision like that to keep help me keep my vision.

Now Lisa was angry, so genuinely angry, that Venti decided to reveal something he would've preferred to keep a secret.

—If you're thinking she just proposed because of this situation, I'll have you know that's not the case—. She looked at him feeling suspicious. —Believe me, I'm not supposed to reveal this, and I didn't want to, but you have to know she just rushed what she had been planning for months now. I'm sure she's furious as all her careful preparation got spoiled like this because of that ambassador's unexpected visit.

His tone was so confident she couldn't help but believe him.

—How do you know that?

—Because Jean asked me to teach her this ancient traditional poem that mondstadters used to recite centuries ago— he answered. —She said you'd appreciate the detail.

For a second she felt breathless. It was, indeed, such a well-thought plan, it now hurt her even more how everything turned out.

She was about to speak again when a sudden noise almost startled them, calling the attention of the bard and the witch toward a nearby column.

—Eavesdropping, I see...— Lisa pointed out nonchalantly.

Captain Kaeya was standing behind the column with Lumine and Paimon, the latter having accidentally given their position away.

—Apologies, Lisa. We didn't mean to spy— Kaeya said, raising his hands in a gesture of innocence. —We were looking for you and wouldn't dare interrupt your conversation.

—So you preferred to listen in— she replied, unamused. —Maybe I should get going.

—Lisa, wait!— Paimon called out.

—Before we left the Headquarters, Jean was screaming in her office, we had to...— Lumine tried to explain, but the witch raised her hand and she had to stop speaking.

—I know. But you, Captain, should have known better— she sentenced with a severe expression.

For once, Kaeya was serious instead of playful.

—I'm doing what I have to— he answered. —You're the only one who could calm her down. But if you won't, just do us a favor and don't avoid her— he requested, looking at her with unnerving confidence.

She wouldn't admit it, but she needed to hear that; of course, her first instinct would be to avoid her for a while, but knowing the background of Jean's actions, she needed the reminder that, this time, it was better to talk about the matter as soon as possible. She looked back at him, nodded once, and disappeared in a blink again.

Once gone, Venti turned around and said —You just need to give them some time—. Then, with a fake innocent smile, he asked —Now, what is all that "Inazuma ambassador" situation? Care to enlighten me?

—In simple terms, the Electro Archon sent a lackey to get Lisa's vision and we have no legal proof of her citizenship; if we had, at least, some papers to give that guy, he would have to return to Inazuma empty-handed— Kaeya briefly explained, a bit annoyed.

—Legal proof…— Venti repeated, scratching his chin deep in thought. —It makes no sense — he muttered. He then looked at Lumine, seeming to suddenly remember —Weren't you looking for a way into Inazuma? Have you found any?

She nodded.

—We can leave next week— Paimon commented.

Venti nodded, apparently pleased, and then addressed Kaeya.

—In the meantime, I suppose you will keep watch on the ambassador.

—Of course— he replied with his usual tone. —Can't let our esteemed guest unprotected during his stay, can we?

City of Mondstadt, Goth Grand Hotel, midnight:

A few odd looks followed the librarian as she walked to the reception of the Hotel. Everyone knew only the Fatui were currently occupying the place, yet she was aware one room had been rented for the Inazuman Ambassador.

—He said he'll meet you here shortly— the receptionist assured her, once the errand boy had returned from informing the ambassador about Lisa's request to speak with him. —Please, feel free to take a seat in the lobby to wait.

The witch sat on one of the sofas, mentally going through what she planned to say, and her hand absentmindedly kept toying with her vision as feeling it right there felt comforting. She was so focused on her own thoughts she never noticed how the few Fatui who passed by kept staring at her, some in confusion, and some fearful she'd shock anyone who dared bother her.

—Miss Minci— called the ambassador's voice as soon as he saw her. —I'm surprised by your visit— he admitted, while taking a seat on another sofa in front of her. He made a gesture with his hand and an errand boy, the same Lisa saw when she asked to speak with him, quickly rushed away. —I suppose you didn't come to hand in your vision, did you?

Her hand instinctively closed around it tightly.

She gritted her teeth and forced herself to remain polite while answering —Sorry to disappoint, but I won't. I'd like to discuss this "estrangement" issue you talked about in the meeting.

Right when she had finished speaking, the errand boy returned carrying a set of tea; he placed it in front of the ambassador, steam rising from the teapot, and left silently.

—I understand— he said, reaching for the teapot to serve some tea in a cup, then in another one. —May I offer you a cup of tea to continue this conversation? You seem like a reasonable woman, I'm sure we can reach an agreement— he offered.

—I wouldn't mind, thank you— she accepted. How could she possibly refuse? —I know you're doing your job and were given precise orders, but if I may, which would be the conditions I need to fulfill to keep my vision?— she asked, calmly taking the cup of tea between her hands.

The ambassador took a sip of his own and answered —Citizenship, as I've explained, defines who is under the protection of their regional archon, and our Bakufu would never interfere with another archon in such delicate affairs like the visions—. He took another sip and

continued —For the Bakufu, citizenship is sacred, and when someone leaves their motherland, estrangement begins. You may consider yourself a citizen of Mondstadt, but what stops you from leaving tomorrow, settling down in -say- Fontaine, and start calling yourself a citizen of Fontaine?

Lisa patiently listened to him while sipping her tea, and only when he was done, she put her cup down, placed both hands calmly on her lap, and took a deep breath before replying.

—You have a point, Ambassador. But not having material things keeping me in Mondstadt, doesn't mean I would simply leave. I have, in fact, plenty of reasons to stay, the same for which I returned from Sumeru.

—I suppose you're speaking of the Grand Master I met today— he commented.

Trying to quickly cover her blush, she answered —You could say so, for starters. However, I must admit I feel indebted to Mondstadt, maybe I should have returned earlier, and I do my best now to help keep it safe. Moreover, I have a little pupil, Razor, who also wields electro, and I would never abandon the child just like that—. She straightened her position to firmly pronounce —So yes, I am a citizen of Mond, maybe not in the papers, but my heart is here, with my partner, my pupil, with the people who received me despite the years I was away, my friends, old and new.

The ambassador finished his tea, put the cup down, and let out a sigh.

—Miss Minci, it is clear to me what you are trying to say, and I would like to accept that as enough proof of your citizenship. Unfortunately, I can't— he sentenced. She closed her eyes, barely holding her breath, and didn't dare say a word. —The best I can do for you, is to give you a week to find any legal affair you may complete soon enough, and if you can provide me with the papers, I will let you keep your vision— he offered. She opened her eyes almost instantly, a glimmer of hope in her eyes. —You have my word— he promised.

The witch felt at ease for the first time since his arrival but tried to keep herself composed despite her desire to laugh and enjoy that small success. She got up, politely thanked him for his time and the tea, and left the hotel without further problems.

City of Mondstadt, Grand Master Jean's residency, midnight:

Jean opened the door and slowly walked in. She felt tired, her muscles ached, so did her throat, and her eyes felt sore. Could she have avoided such an explosion of rage if her week hadn't been so tiresome and full? This wasn't the first time she had vented her anger like that, but it was the first time she felt ashamed of the reason to do it. On other occasions, she had even been told she didn't need to hide her anger, that it was understandable that she wanted to scream and shout at the unfairness of this or that situation. But, this time? How could she lose control like that? And she felt so stupid, it all happened in front of a foreigner, that could easily tarnish her reputation as Grand Master.

—I need a bath and sleep— she muttered, reaching for the bathroom's door. She quickly freshened up and changed into something more comfortable. —It's late and I'm not sleepy— she thought out loud. It was so annoying when she could barely move yet she couldn't sleep, so she went to the kitchen and boiled some water for tea. She couldn't help thinking about what happened, and she wasn't sure when she'd see Lisa again, as she usually cooped herself up in her lab after a situation like that. —Why… Why did you say "no"?— she let out, sighing. She brewed a cup of tea and when she had just sat at the table, she heard the door. Her sight immediately darted towards the entrance, as she called —Lisa?

The witch walked into the kitchen, a soft expression took over her face upon noticing Jean was drinking some tea, for once trying to sleep instead of staying awake.

—Jean, Dear, you're already back— she said with a cheerful tone. She took a seat in front of her and offered a gentle smile. —You weren't expecting me to be back tonight, right?

Jean blushed and looked down, eyes fixed on her cup. She shook her head and took a sip.

After a few seconds of silence, she finally asked —What's different this time?

Lisa couldn't hide her sorrow. She extended her arms across the table and took one of Jean's hands between hers, letting her hold the cup with the other. For a moment, she just focused on the warmth of Jean's hand felt through her gloves.

—You don't deserve it, the silence and distance— Lisa began. —It was a tense situation, had it been any other time maybe… I just can't stand the idea of us marrying for political reasons or anything like that— she expressed. —Even if you really meant it, in this situation it only felt like a means to an end. And I don't want that.

Jean let go of the cup and put her free hand above Lisa's, just holding them there for a moment.

—I understand— she finally said. —And I apologize, I panicked and I regret how I did it, but I still…— she was saying, when Lisa interrupted her, letting go of her hand and cupping her face.

—I'd like to wait till you find a good moment to properly propose— she told her, winking teasingly at the end, and got up from her chair to give her a light kiss on her forehead. Lisa let go of Jean's face and left the kitchen saying —You should finish your tea before it gets cold.

The witch went to their room and changed into her nightclothes while considering whether to tell Jean about her conversation with the ambassador the next day or as soon as possible. And by the time she came into the room, Lisa had gathered enough courage to breach the subject.

—Listen… I went to speak with the Inazuman Ambassador before coming back— she began.

Surprised, Jean asked —You did?

Lisa nodded and continued —It's clear that the Bakufu follows very strict rules and regulations but… I got a week to do whatever to get some legal proof of my citizenship.

Jean sat on the bed next to her with a mix of surprise and happiness. For a moment she was in shock, but the next, she embraced Lisa tightly and let out a relieved sigh.

—I should have trusted you from the beginning— Jean muttered.

Lisa giggled and wrapped her arms around Jean's waist.

—I know you trust me, you did, Love. You just panicked, that's it— Lisa assured her.

—I'm just surprised, I hadn't even thought about having a civil conversation after what happened, and just… how did you do it?— she asked, letting go to look at her face.

The witch brushed it aside and simply answered —Oh, I was just honest and he seemed to appreciate that.

Her hand went to grab Jean's chin gently and Lisa looked into her eyes with a mix of nostalgia and desire.

—Would you be honest with me for a moment?— Jean asked.

—Of course, Dear.

—If it was the other way around; if my vision had to be taken, what would you have done?— Jean asked, with genuine curiosity but also a bit of selfishness.

What would *her* Lisa do for Jean?

The witch's expression turned almost lustful as she answered, whispering in Jean's ear, —I'm not as gentle as you, I'd have electrocuted him as soon as he spoke your name.

Jean suppressed a laugh, she should have expected it. She only smiled and leaned against Lisa's face, caressing her cheek with her nose, and closed her eyes while letting herself enjoy the proximity of the witch.

Lisa slowly turned around, let go of Jean's chin, and repositioned her legs to surround Jean's. Her hands wrapped her back, gently tugging her clothes, and slowly uncovered her neck for Lisa to kiss.

—You never cease to amaze me— Jean pronounced. —You've proved time and again that I can fully trust you, that you won't get out of hand…— Jean kept talking, while Lisa's kisses got more intense. She felt breathless for a moment but finally said —… and that I can even trust you with my life.

Lisa looked into her eyes and smiled softly.

—You flatter me, Dear— she teased her, lightly kissing her lips. —But I'm surprised at your sudden outburst of honesty and expression of feelings— she continued. —Did that surprise visit really affect you so much?

Jean knew Lisa was just being a bit playful, but she was right. She had almost taken Lisa for granted, and this situation that could potentially change Lisa forever, made her feel a little more greedy than usual.

—Maybe—, Jean said, leaning back on the mattress, —I suppose I need some distraction.

Lisa caught the lead almost instantly and loosened Jean's hair with one hand, while the other got the rim of her clothes and began to undress her.

—Then please, allow me, my Love, to provide said distraction.

The witch made quick work of Jean's top clothes and wrapped her arms around her, pressing their bodies together, while kissing her jaw. Jean relaxed in her arms, she could feel Lisa's warmth through her nightclothes against her bare skin, and her kisses kept giving her goosebumps. Slowly, the kisses moved down her throat and reached her chest, and Jean lost the strength in her arms, letting her back hit the mattress under them. Lisa caught her wrists and held her in place, almost as if she had just pounced on her, and the lust in her eyes only intensified.

Her kisses became a little harder, one or two bites here and there, which made Jean moan, and then more kisses just to tease her. The witch could feel Jean struggling to escape her grip, and the more she struggled, the more she teased, leaving more tender kisses, barely licking Jean's nipples when she knew she was craving more. Her breath became more labored, Lisa heard her faint moaning and now she felt aroused. She sat on Jean and let go of her wrists to cup Jean's boobs, her kisses returned to her throat and teased her there, biting a little and then sucking tenderly.

—Lisa…— Jean gasped. —Come on…— she begged.

Amused, the witch released Jean, who remained on the mattress depleted of strength, and let her watch as she took off her clothes. Even breathless, Jean seemed to want nothing more than to reach for her and return all of Lisa's teasing. But she wouldn't let Jean move, and instead leaned over her, brushing her hair aside.

—Sorry, did you want this, Dear?

Jean wrapped her arms around Lisa and began kissing her chest with such need and passion it almost caught the witch by surprise. She could barely keep herself from falling on Jean, and didn't bother holding back her moans, which became loud gasps when she began sucking Lisa's nipple.

Their worries seemed to have vanished into the ether, they only cared about each other, for a couple of hours, nothing else in the world mattered.

City of Mondstadt, Grand Master Jean's residency, early morning:

For the first time in, possibly, ever, Lisa got up from bed before Jean. Maybe she usually woke up very early, but getting up was an entirely different matter. She was almost done putting her clothes on when Jean woke up and noticed her.

—Lisa?— she called her, confused.

—Ah, good morning Jean— she greeted her. —Slept well?

Lisa caressed Jean's face gently, brushing away a few strands of loose hair, and carefully bowed down to give her a kiss. Jean's torso was still naked, and while Lisa would have preferred to stay and enjoy the view of the sleepy and half-naked woman, she knew she had to get going as soon as possible.

—I… yes… but, why are you up already?— Jean asked.

—I may have gotten a week of grace, as I told you last night, but to get any legal process completed before my time runs out, I need to get started as soon as possible— she answered, walking up and down the room to make sure she had everything she needed. —Don't worry, it's really early so you can stay and sleep a bit more. And I left you some pancakes I just made, if you'd like to have breakfast— she commented. Before finally leaving, she went back to the bed and gave Jean a brief kiss —I'll see you for lunch, alright?

Jean was still very tired and could only nod before the witch left the house. Her senses were still half numb, but it was the surprise of seeing Lisa so active that early which kept her in bed for about half an hour before she finally got up.

What was her plan? To have left this early, Lisa must have a well-thought plan and wouldn't lose a single second. Or maybe she has several ideas on what she can do to get the legal proof she needs and wants to have enough time to check every possibility today.

Jean kept musing to herself, trying to understand what had gotten into Lisa, but quickly got changed into her usual clothes and went to have breakfast.

She brewed herself a mug of coffee and ate one of the pancakes Lisa had left for her, it still felt warm and the sweetness quickly lifted her mood and brought back memories.

It was a sweet nostalgic remembrance: a few years earlier, it was already late and she was still working; as per usual, Lisa showed up in her office to try and convince her to finish for the day, but this one time, when Jean looked up, the witch had brought her a tray with tea and pancakes instead. She could still remember the warmth she felt inside when Lisa smiled gently, holding the tray a little higher, in a silent offering. Jean took her paperwork from her desk and went to take a seat at the table. Lisa sat across from her and just watched Jean enjoy the food, casually taking a look at her papers. Jean would never know what struck her that moment; maybe just the detail of letting her work but giving her a little comfort instead of just dragging her away from work she wanted to do, or maybe realizing that she would rather stay with her in companionable silence all night than finish early and go back to a cold and empty house, but whatever it was seemed to possess her. Jean left her papers aside for a moment and took one of Lisa's hands; she wasn't even nervous because she wasn't even thinking, she just began thanking her for the food and, barely registering her words, she

confessed how much Lisa's company meant to her, and how she wished to never be parted from her. Only the witch's expression brought her back to reality, and for a moment she even regretted her indiscretion, but Lisa finally smiled and pulled Jean's hand towards her mouth to kiss her knuckles. Jean rarely recalled her abrupt confession, but never once regretted it again.

—Alright, morning run, and then my duties…— she told herself before leaving the house.

City of Mondstadt, Library of the Knights of Favonius, afternoon:

The library was silent, orange light came in through the windows and some people occupied the tables downstairs. In one of them, Amber and Barbara were going through various books, quickly discarding each of them after a shallow review, but tall piles of books still had to be assessed.

—I can't understand how there's nothing in any of these— Amber muttered, clearly annoyed.

—If we could find at least one precedent of knighthood that was granted on the spot, without the years of training and trials…— Barbara sighed, she realized it was mostly wishful thinking, but there could be at least one time when the circumstances allowed it.

—Barbara— Amber called her. —I forgot to ask… there is absolutely no registry related to Lisa in the cathedral?

Barbara shook her head. She herself wasn't sure why, but there really was nothing.

They kept going through the books until the voices from Lisa's desk called their attention.

—…Are you serious? This is the first time you haven't come into my office to have a tea break, whether I want it or not— Jean was complaining. She sighed and spoke with a calmer tone. —You seemed so cheerful this morning, but then completely forgot about lunch and afternoon tea; what happened?

Amber and Barbara walked upstairs and stayed just out of sight. Jean was standing in front of Lisa's desk, while the witch stayed seated, not even daring to look at her.

—I had a lot of possibilities, or… it seemed like there were several things I could try to get those documents…— she tried to answer. Lisa's voice kept trailing off and Jean began to worry. —That ambassador is right… in formal papers, I am not a citizen.

—Stop it— Jean interrupted her. She walked closer and took Lisa's hands. —You didn't want to tell me you haven't solved this yet? That was it?— she asked her, and Lisa nodded a bit insecure. Jean sighed. —Do you realize solving this so quickly would have been basically a miracle? So please… don't ever keep me in the dark again— she added, her voice severe but her expression soft.

—My best bet is to be granted knighthood but… that normally takes years and unless there's any precedent of such an exception ever being made, it just can't be done either— Lisa

explained.

Astonished, Jean asked —You don't pretend to go over the registry by yourself, do you?

Lisa giggled and tipped her head towards the stairs.

—Of course not, Dear. Amber and Barbara gently offered their help, they've been revising all the registry books I could find.

As soon as she said that, Jean looked back at the stairs and, when she noticed both girls were standing there watching, she let go of Lisa's hands and quickly composed her expression.

She cleared her throat and formally addressed them —Outrider Amber, Deaconess, thank you for your help but you can return to your duties. I assure you there's enough staff in the library to help with this matter.

—But, Master Jean, we wanted to…— Amber began replying, but Jean lifted a hand and interrupted her.

—I understand, Outrider, but you still have your own duties. So please, now, you both can return— she insisted.

Jean looked back at Lisa for a brief moment and then walked towards the door before Amber and Barbara. Lisa saw all three of them out and sighed.

Dragonspine, Albedo's camp above Wyrmrest Valley, mid-day:

After another day of fruitless review, Lisa gave up on the knighthood idea, which she wasn't really fond of, and decided to explore more possibilities. On the third day of her week, she went to find Albedo and Sucrose on Dragonspine, where they had settled a small workshop within a cave. She reached the camp rather quickly but the cold biting her skin made it feel like an eternity.

After some hours of discussion, Albedo told her —When put in the ambassador's terms, there are many residents of Mondstadt who wouldn't be citizens. I believe, under the circumstances, owning any property in Mondstadt would be the quickest way to get legal citizenship to satisfy the ambassador's requirements—. While he spoke, Sucrose had been rummaging among the papers and trinkets stashed in their shelves, until she found a piece of parchment carefully rolled into a scroll. Albedo quickly skimmed through it and finally said —Indeed, this is the only written statement about the alchemy workshop's property. This should let you formally register it to your name. Hopefully, the procedure won't take too long.

Lisa took the scroll and held it with both hands; it felt almost sacred, especially since she was unaware of its existence.

—I have four days, actually less; if this doesn't work…— she muttered, but interrupted herself. Shaking her thoughts aside, she asked him —Why did you have this?

—I don't really know, if I'm honest— he answered, maintaining a calm tone as he didn't consider it relevant.

However, Sucrose chimed in when she heard the question and commented —Actually, some of these papers have been moved around along with the rest of the things on these shelves for years now. We never know what can be found that may be useful—. She wouldn't dare look at Lisa while speaking, but the witch knew it was just her shyness. Sucrose pushed her glasses back and said —I'm glad this can be of help.

—Oh, well, aren't you a cutie? Thank you for this, to both of you— she expressed.

She turned to head back, but surprisingly, Albedo's voice called out to her for a moment.

He approached her and kept his voice lowered to ask —Will you need any help to prepare the place for examination, miss Lisa? I admit most of the dangerous chemicals were left either by me or Sucrose, you needn't deal with them.

—You're very generous, but there's no need, Albedo. I can assure you everything is perfectly secured— she replied. However, something felt odd. —Was that really what you wanted to ask?

Albedo's demeanor was serious, almost somber.

—Perceptive as always, miss Lisa— he sighed. —I don't have a good feeling about the Inazuman ambassador, but I also have no reason to leave Dragonspine. Maybe I'm just looking for an excuse to go to the city while he's here. I'm afraid I can't properly explain myself more than that.

Lisa recognized that worrisome gut feeling of his, as she herself had experienced it several times, and perfectly understood him.

She just giggled a bit and replied —Please, Albedo, don't tangle yourself in unnecessary troubles. You are allowed to go to the city if you want to, you know? And you're also allowed to ignore your suspicion and stay away from this whole affair—. With an honest smile, she stated —You have already done all you could in this situation. It is already enough.

Chapter End Notes

Act 2 unlocked

Act 2: Baal's Will

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

City of Mondstadt, Grand Master Jean's residency, late night:

Jean arrived home, late as usual, and went straight to take a bath. When she came out, refreshed, she found Lisa reading a book, comfortably seated on the bed, with her legs covered by the sheets.

—What are you reading tonight?— Jean asked, sitting on the other side of the bed while drying her hair with a towel.

—Oh, nothing really interesting… Well, maybe a bit, but it could be better— she answered, never looking away from her book.

—Care to explain?

—Ah…— Lisa sighed, half a smile escaping her lips. —The boring part is the clearly philosophical intention of the author but, it's a bit interesting because of who the "speaker" is — she explained. —That is: this is a philosophical treatise about madness and foolishness, but… the one who would be speaking is foolishness herself.

Jean put down her towel and looked at Lisa perplexed.

—Could you run that by me again?— she asked, trying not to sound too confused.

Lisa giggled and closed her book.

—Don't worry, it is just something scholar authors do. As I said, it's not really interesting— she replied. —Besides, I may have a thing or two to discuss with the author, he certainly has quite the nerve writing some of these paragraphs…

Jean lay down next to her and hugged her waist while Lisa stayed seated with her back against the bed frame; the witch caressed Jean's hair and felt her slowly fall asleep as her breath became fainter.

—So exhausted, my knight…— Lisa murmured. —At least you will have a good night of sleep.

The witch kept caressing her hair with her right hand and with the other made her book levitate in front of her and open where she had left. She read for a couple of hours, too anxious about the next day to actually fall asleep, but remained unfocused and finally closed the book again. She looked at her hand, then sideways to her vision on the night desk, and back at her hand. With ease, she cast a small lightning orb and kept it hovering over her hand while she looked into it as if there was anything new to discover. But it was the same orb she had come to get used to, the power felt like always, and Lisa couldn't begin to imagine not

being able to cast it. At the same time, however, she cursed herself for allowing it to be such an important part of herself.

Why did she let the electro power have such an influence on her? What would she do without it? If she lost it, could she even adjust to life back as a “normal” person? Part of her screamed it was impossible, that she’d rather die than let her sacrifice be wasted. Her control of electro energy came, she was sure, at a very high price, and she couldn’t possibly let it be snatched from her just like that. But…

She looked at Jean sleeping soundly, her head on Lisa’s lap, and her worried expression melted away. Of course she could go on living without electro; it was her most important, and in a way expensive, tool, but it was nothing compared to everything she had come back to in Mondstadt. She remembered what she had told the ambassador, those were her reasons to go on even if she lost her power. She could even lose all her magic, let all her sacrifices go to waste, as long as she could remain in her current life, her daily routines, as they are.

The witch let out a sigh; Jean kept saving her life, plenty of times her sole presence had been enough of a blessing for her, so she would go on, no matter what happened the next day; she owed it to her, didn’t she?

With careful moves, she slid down under the sheets and hold Jean in a tight embrace, hoping to fall asleep soon.

City of Mondstadt, Library of the Knights of Favonius, mid-day:

It was the last day of the week Lisa had been granted, and she was finally breathing easy as the papers would be ready that afternoon. It was the first time in the last week she would actually take a nap on her desk, as she used to, instead of anxiously fidgeting with her quilt for hours.

The witch woke up as she felt hungry, and while she was stretching her arms a bit, Jean came into the library.

—Oh, hello Jean— she greeted her, with her usual languid expression. —Don't tell me you're here to invite me to lunch— she teased her.

Jean looked away a bit embarrassed and slowly approached the desk.

—I suppose… Maybe it would be a good idea to go out for lunch, maybe at the Cat's Tail?— she offered. Her clear nervousness was endearing to Lisa, who stood up and walked around the desk towards Jean. —This whole week you've been restless, but I'm proud of you for not giving up, you know?— she admitted, her voice lower, shy. —I… I had this fear…— Jean began to say, but couldn't find the words. She coughed and tried to compose herself. —I'm ashamed to admit I thought you'd try to run away from the ambassador, anything to make sure he'd never take away your vision, but I suppose it was just the fear of… losing you— she finally said.

Lisa's expression softened, one of her hands cupped Jean's face and her thumb gently caressed her cheek. She wasn't sure if Jean would feel comfortable with more than that as there were more people at the library, so she just tried to express her love with her caring touch.

—Jean, Dear, I'm not going anywhere without you— she pronounced. —Or at least, if I had to, I'd make sure I can return to you as soon as possible— she added. —I know your duties will always keep you here, and I don't wish to make you choose, so I would always find a way to come back to you— she clarified. Then, with a bright smile, she concluded —Good thing I don't have to leave at all.

Jean held Lisa's hand against her cheek and smiled faintly at her good-natured words.

—Lisa, if you had had to leave…—, she closed her eyes feeling the warmth of her hand, and continued, —I would have chosen to follow you—. Taken aback, Lisa just stared at her, and listened as Jean recited:

As the winds of Barbatos,

I wish to always be by your side.

Wherever your freedom takes you,

shall you allow me to follow;

be it close to home or far away,

be it Celestia or Mare Jivari,

let my soul seek yours

even after our stars fade away.

A single tear rolled down Lisa's cheek, her eyes felt watery but she wouldn’t dare close them, she kept staring at Jean; her calm expression and the confidence in her voice, despite sounding serious as her command voice, along with the amount of feeling she had imprinted the verses with, was beyond compare. Lisa felt breathless.

Jean finally opened her eyes a little, looked into Lisa's, and asked —Would you grant me that wish?

Lisa recognized the tradition since the first word, and she was already expecting it, but she never imagined Jean would perfectly stick to it; her mind felt completely disarmed, even intellectually, for Jean had found a way to make it special for both of them.

She closed the distance between them and rested her forehead against Jean's, whispering —Of course I would, my Dandelion Knight—. Lisa wanted to kiss Jean, but something caught her eye and she just knew Jean was absolutely unaware of them. —Well, look who's here— she said cheerfully, leading Jean's attention to Lumine and Paimon, barely a few meters away from them.

—Ah- Honorary knight— Jean noticed. Lisa felt a bit bad but giggled at Jean's shyness once again. —How long have you two been there?

Paimon laughed nervously and scratched her neck.

—Maybe just enough to have seen all of that— she admitted.

Jean let out a grunt and crossed her arms in front of her chest.

—Venti told you, didn't he?

Lumine nodded, but before Jean could say anything, Lisa hugged her from behind and said —Aw, come on, Jean, she won't tell a soul about your soft side; will you, Cutie?

Jean turned around saying —Lisa, you don't…—, but suddenly stopped talking.

Lisa saw her expression go rigid, a hint of shock told her she had seen something unsettling. But Jean's eyes were fixed on Lisa’s collar, and behind her, Lumine and Paimon also looked bewildered.

Her first instinct was to grab her vision and lift it. Her hand shook, holding the dull vision, now gray and empty.

—It can't be— Lisa declared. —No, no, there's no way. I… I still feel the electro energy, I…— she kept saying, her voice weaker each passing moment. —This… this can't be— she insisted, looking at her hand as she tried, and failed, to summon a lightning orb.

—Lisa…— Jean called, but the witch wasn't listening.

—No, just… No!— she screamed, stubbornly trying to cast at least a tiny spark.

Her mind clouded completely, she turned around, pulled her vision off, and threw it to her desk, a brief moment of anger she quickly suppressed as soon as she saw it hit the books she had been reading hours ago. The next moment, she felt Jean's hands on her shoulders and it made her hyper-aware of her surroundings and behavior.

—Lisa, please, breathe— Jean begged.

—I've been a fool— Lisa let out. —After all these years, despite my own fears, I made electro such an important part of my life… I shouldn't have— she said, thinking out loud. With a bitter laugh, she added —Now I'm basically handicapped, and I did this to myself. I should have known something like this could happen one day, it was so foolish of me…—. And suddenly she stopped. The witch took a deep breath, slowly let it out, and, as if nothing had happened, she looked back at Lumine and asked her —Say, Cutie, could you do me a favor? Would you please go find Razor? I'm afraid… This wasn't an isolated incident.

Lumine nodded, and before she and Paimon could leave the library, Jean told her —Find us in my office when you're back.

City of Mondstadt, outside the Adventurers Guild Headquarters, mid-day:

Unsure where to start looking for Razor, Lumine decided to go to Cyrus and ask if maybe Razor had accepted any commissions recently. However, when they arrived at the Adventurers Guild Headquarters, Paimon quickly noticed Razor was sitting with Bennett on one of the benches just outside.

—Razor! Bennett!— Paimon called, waving at them.

They both walked up to them and realized Razor was looking down while Bennett seemed to be trying to cheer him up.

—Ah… Honorary knight— Bennett noticed. —You came at a bad time— he said, apologetically. —I… My bad luck seems to have affected Razor— he explained, noticeably ashamed.

—Wait, wait— Paimon interrupted. —What happened to Razor?

—My lightning fang… gone… I can't protect lupical— he answered, looking at his hands with sorrow.

—I'll help you protect your lupical, Razor, I promised— Bennett told him, trying to sound confident.

—Bennett is lupical too. I can't protect Bennett— he insisted.

—So… Razor's vision isn't working— Paimon concluded.

—We were about to take on a commission— Bennett began explaining. —Fischl was also here, she wanted to help us because it was an A rank commission. But…—, he looked away and seemed to be looking for the words to explain it. —We didn't even realize it happened, Oz suddenly told Fischl he was feeling bad, and then we noticed her vision was dull, and Razor's too, and…

—Bennett, calm down, please— Lumine interrupted him, putting her hands on his shoulders; he stopped and took a deep breath. —We know. Alright? Don't panic, it was not your bad luck.

—Of course it wasn't— Paimon chimed in.

—Where is Fischl?— Lumine asked.

Bennett looked back at Razor for a moment and sighed.

—I didn't want to leave him alone, so I suggested she go find Mona and ask her to use her… eh… something, maybe she could tell her what happened and, meanwhile, we'd wait here— he explained. Then he seemed to notice something behind Lumine and added —Ah, there they are.

Both girls were walking their way, their distressed expressions darkened the general mood even more. Fischl was holding Oz in her arms, and Paimon couldn't help gasping at the sight; they had never seen Oz so weak.

—Oh, Lumine, you're here too— Mona noticed, as soon as she looked up. —We can't waste any time, we have to find miss Lisa; I read something that… I just can't believe this, we have to make sure this is true— she explained, a bit too excitedly, but clearly worried.

—Actually, Lisa sent us to check on Razor; we should all head back to Jean's office— Lumine replied.

The six of them set on their way to the Knights of Favonius' Headquarters, but Paimon seemed scared, and when Lumine noticed, she lowered her pace to encourage her to speak.

—Paimon is scared— she said. —What can this mean? And what are we going to do when we get to Inazuma? Pa-Paimon doesn't want to fight an archon!

—Let's hope there's no need to fight. And… this means we'll *have* to convince Baal of restoring the electro visions.

City of Mondtstadt, Grand Master's office, afternoon:

It had almost been an hour since the visions went out, when Lumine arrived at Jean's office followed by Razor, Bennett, Fischl, and Mona. Both Jean and Lisa gasped when they saw Fischl carrying Oz in her arms, and Mona's presence made it clear: their electro visions must have waned.

—A-Acting Grand Master— Mona said, a bit shy. —I believe there's something important I need to discuss with miss Lisa, I… I can barely believe my readings— she blurted out.

Meanwhile, the children stayed silent, Lumine and Paimon wouldn't dare talk, and Jean decided to let Lisa handle the situation for a while.

—Believe them, Mona, but please tell us what information you gathered— Lisa asked her.

However, when Razor heard her voice, he automatically looked up and ran to Lisa. His sudden hug took her by surprise, but she quickly understood how he was feeling and hugged him back gently.

—Master! I lost lightning tooth! I can't protect lupical!— he cried, more frantic than sad, and then let go of her to stare at his hands once again, missing his inner wolf.

—Oh dear…— Lisa sighed. —Listen to me, Little Wolfie— she said, trying to hide her sorrow. —You can still protect them, alright? But now they will protect you too.

Razor shook his head and replied —No! I can't let them hurt again!

Lisa placed her hands on his shoulders and looked into his eyes.

—They won't, I promise. You will be safe with them, alright?

Razor was still feeling distressed, so she looked up and locked eyes with Bennett. He immediately understood and went to help him take a seat and calm down.

Once Lisa glanced back at Mona, the astrologer took out her astrolabe and said —I keep seeing the same, no matter how many times I check… every electro vision seems to have… died.

Everyone froze at that, and only Fischl dared speak.

—Impossible! Who would dare slander the Prinzessin and her most loyal servant, Oz, with whom one shares soul and fate, who… who…— she began speaking in all earnest and in her usual manner, but her peroration quickly stopped and her voice broke as her sorrow took over. She knelt, holding Oz closer to her, and cried —I can't lose him! I… I'm so sorry…

—Please, don't cry, mein Fräulien— Oz answered.

None of them had ever seen Fischl so vulnerable, and Lumine quickly went to her side to try and calm her down.

—What does this mean?— Jean whispered.

—I'm not sure yet— Lisa admitted. —Fischl, Dear— she called. —I'll give you something to help Oz— she stated. —Just do me a favor and stay strong for him, will you?

Fischl nodded, still sobbing, and brushed away her tears, some of which were sipping from under her eyepatch. Lumine placed a hand on Fischl's back, caressing gently to soothe her.

A knock on the door startled them and Jean went to open, hyperconscious of the situation they were all in. It was Noelle and Amber, the outrider had just arrived while Noelle had apparently been called by Lisa unbeknown to anyone.

—Ah, please come in— Jean told Amber, and then moved away to let Lisa address Noelle.

While Lumine and Paimon were informing Amber about everything that had happened, Lisa asked Noelle to get her some Lightning Prisms from her workshop. Once they closed the door, Lisa briefly looked at Jean before speaking up.

—For the time being, I am sorry to say there isn't much I can do— she began. The witch looked at Razor for a moment and said —If you don't mind, Bennett, can I ask you to take him back to Wolvendom? I know Andrius will take good care of him… While I… now, I simply can't—. Her pain could be heard in her voice as much as seen in her eyes. She was afraid, just as Razor himself, that she couldn't protect anyone anymore. The boys stood up and walked out of the office. After closing the door again, Lisa looked at Fischl, who had finally sat on a chair with the help of Lumine and Amber, and gently told her —I understand you created and maintained Oz's form with your own electro energy. So I will give you as many Lightning Prisms as you need to keep his form stable. Would that be alright?

—I… I would- appreciate- it- thank you— she answered, her voice interrupted by her sobs, not a trace of her usual demeanor and manner of speech.

Amber and Lumine exchanged a concerned look and kept trying to calm her down. A moment later, Noelle was once again knocking on the door. She handed Lisa a small fabric package that the witch opened on the table in front of Fischl.

—Ah…— Oz sighed. —This is most welcomed.

—I'll make sure you always have enough of those— Lisa promised.

—Let me help you gather more, okay?— Jean asked her, keeping her voice lowered, and Lisa nodded.

Fischl finally seemed to breathe easier and, accompanied by Amber, she left the office. Shortly after, Lumine and Paimon also left, with Jean's orders to inform Venti about the situation.

Once Jean, Lisa, and Mona were alone, they sat to discuss the particular situation they were in and how they could deal with it now. However, Lisa's grumbling stomach interrupted.

—Oh dear— she sighed, a bit embarrassed.

—Right! I had promised you lunch— Jean remembered. —I'm so sorry, Lisa…

—No, please, it's fine. Besides, I don't know how I would explain what happened to my vision— she replied.

—Well, the news about Fischl and Razor's vision is probably all over the city already…

—Ah, don't worry, Jean— Lisa interrupted. —I'll just ask Noelle if she can bring us some food— she said, walking towards the door. —For you too, Mona, don't worry— she giggled.

It caught Mona off guard, and she gasped, suddenly self-conscious.

—Ah, eh… well, thank you. It would be impolite to turn down such a kind offer— she finally managed to say, pretending it hadn't affected her pride.

After the witch's request, they finally sat and discussed Mona's findings, what had happened with the Inazuman ambassador, and what they knew about the current situation of the region; they were only briefly interrupted by Noelle bringing their food, but afterward, they discussed the rest of the afternoon.

The sun was already down when Noelle knocked on the door bringing a letter.

—Excuse me, Grand Master, but this letter came with high priority, from Liyue— she explained. —From the Tianquan of the Liyue Qixing.

—Ah, yes; thank you, Noelle— Jean answered, taking the letter. After she left, the Grand Master quickly opened it, fearing the worst, and began reading it, occasionally voicing the

important parts. —So… Ningguang seems to have received an Inazuman Ambassador just yesterday… Instead of going to talk with her he just went for the visions he had to retrieve… Those affected got the Millelith involved, and only then she met him, but… Give me a second— Jean said, focussing intently, apparently rereading the last part. —Well, this… Actually, it makes sense. So, they couldn't reach an agreement with the ambassador yesterday, and he seemed to be looking for the Crux Fleet's captain, so they continued the discussion today, about… Ah… about whether Beidou should be considered estranged from Liyue or not. However, apparently, they were still discussing when the Yuheng of the Liyue Qixing noticed her vision went out.

—Oh my… That's...— Lisa gasped, but hesitated to continue. —It could potentially be seen as an attack on Liyue's government; it's extremely dangerous.

Jean denied with a gesture and assured —I don't think it will escalate that much; the Liyue Qixing is very moderate, they wouldn't risk potential war over something without proof—. Then, she finished reading, once again voicing the most important bits of the letter. —They decided to keep the ambassador under custody, and want our opinion on the matter about how to proceed. Oh wow…

—So they *are* considering the conflict— Lisa noticed.

—I would say… They realize their next move will determine how this will unfold but they must suspect we had a similar situation— Jean replied. —Ah, right, the letter mentioned every electro vision waned too; so they may already suspect this wasn't actually an attack or anything similar. But again, if they retaliate, they probably want our support.

Lisa looked back at Mona who was already checking her astrolabe. After several readings, she sighed and shook her head lightly.

—Conflict is the worst possible path to take— the astrologist said, dead serious. —The diplomatic solution won't be easy either, but it's the only way out of this situation without major losses… maybe.

—Maybe?— Jean repeated.

—I-I just know we will regret it if war breaks out between Inazuma and both Liyue and Mondstadt.

—Well, that shouldn't happen, anyways— Lisa answered. —The Tianquan asked for your opinion on the matter; you can explain to her what happened, that the issue with the vision isn't targeting Liyue but all of Teyvat, so whatever they will do about it is ultimately their decision— she suggested. —As much as it's yours whether this ends here and we let the ambassador return to Inazuma or not.

Jean was clearly not expecting that from Lisa; in a way, she seemed completely neutral about the situation, as if she hadn't been affected, and there was a conscious effort to let Jean decide for herself.

—Well, I did ask Kaeya to keep his vigilance on the ambassador, but we're not keeping him captive. He can leave whenever he wants to. I don't see why we should hold him captive.

The Grand Master sighed and went to sit on her desk to write an answer for Ningguang. At the same time, Mona stood up and decided to leave.

—If my readings are correct, and they always are even if I don't want them to be this time, there will soon be news from other regions losing the electro visions— Mona said. —Whatever happens next, I'll be at your disposal for any assistance you may need.

—We appreciate it, Mona— Jean thanked her. —We'll keep it in mind.

The astrologist finally retired from the office and Jean focused on writing her answer while Lisa remained seated at the large table, looking outside the window, absentmindedly.

Shortly after, when Jean had dispatched her letter to the Liyue Qixing, she called Lisa's attention.

—Ah…— Lisa sighed. —I wasn't expecting this today… and I still need to go for the papers of the workshop so I can finally get the ambassador off my back. But what was it all for, I lost my vision all the same— she expressed, her sight lost in the night sky.

—Lisa…

—Ah, it's fine, Jean— she assured her, finally looking back at her. —Maybe it's time to call it a day.

Jean took Lisa's hand and helped her up; the exhaustion in the witch's voice was only barely noticeable, yet Jean's support felt indispensable for her.

—Actually, today even *I* should finish early and leave the office— Jean agreed. —Let's close the library and go back home, alright?

Lisa nodded, they grabbed their things and finally headed out.

City of Mondstadt, Library of the Knights of Favonius, evening:

Jean stayed by the door while Lisa went to gather her books from the desk. Behind her, Paimon, Lumine, and Venti knocked on the door, having just seen them walk into the library.

—Evening, Grand Master— Venti said. —The Honorary Knight here told me about the… issue with the visions— he continued, warier and less cheerful. —How is…

His question got interrupted by a sudden loud noise; they all looked at Lisa: her hand, closed in a fist, slammed against the desk.

—Lisa, what…

—It's gone— Lisa answered before Jean could finish her question.

—The vision?— Paimon asked, perplexed.

—He must have taken it— Lisa continued, turning around but keeping her sight fixed on the floor. —I never went for the papers of the workshop, never handed them in, and he just came and took my vision. He simply took it!

She yelled the last part, finally looking up. Jean gasped and extended her arms protectively in front of Lumine and Venti. The witch had reached the point of no return, she couldn't hold back anymore; seeing the electricity arcs around her arms, the dangerous shine in her eyes, Jean's first instinct was to keep everyone safe, but at the same time, she couldn't stop thinking how to stop her from harming herself. Only once had she seen the witch this perilously threatening, but even then, Lisa had been in control.

—Lisa…— Jean called her. —Lisa, listen to me— she insisted. She felt a hand on her right arm but ignored it and continued to call Lisa. —Lisa, please, listen to me.

The witch kept looking into the distance, possibly not even seeing them there, and the things on the desk next to her were now in a conductive state, lightning arcs jumping between them and her arms. Jean noticed she was holding all the electro power within her, as she was now suspended just above the floor, and decided to use her anemo power to pull Lisa back to the floor.

—Wait, careful!— Venti shouted, as soon as he noticed what Jean was about to do, but she had already begun.

Lisa never realized a thing; her feet touched the floor once again and all the electro power suddenly flowed out of her and into the earth below them. She gasped and fell on her knees, and had Jean not jumped to catch her, she would have collapsed on the floor.

—Tha-that was… close— Paimon whispered.

Jean held Lisa between her arms, trying to calm herself down before even attempting to wake her up, and looked back at Venti.

—How did you know it wouldn't cause a swirl reaction?— he asked.

Jean shook her head.

—It would have been worth it, though— she commented. Lisa shivered and opened her eyes, her expression full of pain, and slowly tried to get up. —Take it easy— Jean told her while helping her up, but as soon as she let go of her hand, the witch tripped over and almost fell again. —Better stay down for now, okay?

Lisa barely had any strength left, wouldn't even want to talk, so she didn't refuse and sat down against the bookshelf in front of her desk.

—This can't go on— Venti stated, finally breaking the silence. Everyone, except Lisa, looked at him as he said —I will go to speak with Baal, archon to archon. There is no excuse for her

actions.

They hadn't seen Venti so serious before; Lumine and Jean nodded and he left.

—We should probably leave for Inazuma as soon as possible too— Lumine said.

—So tonight we go to Liyue?— Paimon asked.

Lumine nodded and Jean accompanied her to the door, to close behind her.

Before leaving, Lumine assured her —We'll get this fixed.

City of Mondstadt, Mond's front gate, evening:

Swan and Lawrence were standing guard as per usual, few people came in or out so late, so they paid little attention when the ambassador walked out. However, he hadn't even reached the bridge when a dark shadow jumped down from the city walls and gracefully fell right in front of him.

—If isn't it our esteemed ambassador— Kaeya said, with his usual tone. He looked at Swan and Lawrence who instantly got between the ambassador and the gate, hands on the hilt of their swords. —Leaving so soon?

Kaeya stared at him with such dangerous air he instinctively took a few steps back, only to find the guards blocking the way.

—You can't take me prisoner, the Bakufu will take it as a declaration of war— he said, clearly terrified but trying to stay calm.

Kaeya laughed and shook his head.

—Oh, no, Ambassador, no need to be so dramatic— he began. —Of course you can leave, we wouldn't keep you here. However…—, he took a step towards the him, —I believe you have something that doesn't belong to you.

—The vision was…

—The vision you stole, Ambassador, belongs to our librarian, and your transgression is seen as an offense to the Knights of Favonius as a whole— Kaeya interrupted him.

—Maybe there's too much leverage on her side given the Grand Master is…

—I advise you not to finish that sentence, Ambassador— Kaeya interrupted yet again.

Behind him, however, Swan moved and called his attention. The argument took the guard by surprise and his expression didn't hide it.

—Do you mean…? How could anyone take miss Lisa's vision just like that!?— he let out. —That's an affront to one of the higher ranks of the Knights.

—She's just a clerk!— replied the ambassador, incredulous.

—That's where you're wrong— Kaeya countered. —If you have no idea who you're dealing with, why even wrong her? Especially after, if I recall correctly, you had reached an agreement with her.

—Which she didn't fulfill— the ambassador retorted.

Kaeya, arms crossed in front of his chest, stood his ground and gave him a serious look.

—We are not discussing this anymore, Ambassador. You can return her vision now, or we can stay here all night. You choose.

He couldn't hold Kaeya's stare for long and, behind him, the guards were more than ready to avenge his "affront", as Swan had called it. Finally, he grunted, took out the box, and handed it in. The cavalry captain opened it, found the waned vision inside, and closed it again with a relieved sigh. Without a word, Kaeya took out a copy of Lisa's property papers of her workshop and gave them to the ambassador.

—Here's your legal proof, you can get back to your Bakufu and never again attempt to steal a vision— he stated, with such a sour tone of voice that even the guards felt his anger. —Good night, Ambassador.

City of Mondstadt, Library of the Knights of Favonius, late night:

Jean had knelt next to Lisa; the witch didn't say a word since her outburst, her expression showing how worn out she felt, and her sight lost somewhere in front of her. She couldn't bear seeing Lisa like that, but it was clear she needed time, so Jean just stayed next to her in silence.

Minutes later, the door of the library opened slowly and Kaeya walked in.

—Am I late?— he asked. Jean looked back at him, and he handed her the small wooden box. —We won't be seeing him again any time soon.

Jean took the box and opened it. A mix of relief and sorrow gripped her heart when she saw the waned vision inside, but she couldn't help showing Lisa.

—It's still here, alright?

Lisa closed her eyes, nodded, and replied —Just… leave it on the desk, yes?

Kaeya took the box back, placed it on the desk, and sat in front of Lisa. She finally seemed to be a little more present, but it was obvious she still felt destroyed.

—You know…— Kaeya began speaking. —You're very strong, Lisa.

She let out an incredulous laugh.

—Me? You didn't see what I did. I am not…

—You are— he insisted. —I spoke with Razor and Fischl, also Bennett and Amber. And everything you've done? I'm still impressed— he began. —You managed to keep your composure, helped both children stay calm and do their best in this situation, you even found a solution for Oz's weakening— he numbered. —While I…—, his voice cracked a second, but he quickly continued, —When I was informed of what happened to them, and supposed it had also affected you, I felt such rage. I even broke a chair to bits with a kick. How dared Baal take away your powers!? How could she take a decision like that without considering the consequences!? Now Oz may disappear, you and Razor lost the power to protect yourselves and those you love; but the archons, so arrogant, never think about these things, do they!?

—We are fools for letting the visions become so important— Lisa let out, her voice barely audible but perfectly clear in the empty library.

—No, we are just humans, some more practical than others, and we use what we are given— he replied. —But nothing justifies something so unfair. And it would have been expected from you to curse and yell as soon as your vision went out, but you didn't— he insisted again. —It was your vision getting stolen what finally broke you because it was already too much weight on you.

—He's right, Lisa. You're very reliable, and today would have been a nightmare if you hadn't handled everything— Jean supported him.

—Do us a favor, miss Lisa— Kaeya asked. —I've heard you were already pretty admired before getting your vision… so why don't you show us what you're capable of?

The witch let out half a smile, she still felt tired but his words were exactly what she needed to hear.

—Fine. You're right— she accepted. —But now I need to rest, really… I just used up the last of the electro energy still in me and it feels awful— she sighed, making an effort to get up.

Jean helped her up and after Kaeya made sure Lisa got the box with her vision and the originals of her property papers, he left to let them close the library. However, Lisa felt so weak that Jean decided to lift her and carry her home in her arms; the witch quickly fell asleep and her calm expression was a relief for Jean.

Chapter End Notes

Act 3 unlocked

Act 3: Race Against Time

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

City of Mondstadt, Grand Master Jean's residency, early morning :

Jean woke up with the sun on her face and felt Lisa still soundly asleep between her arms. The witch hadn't moved an inch since she fell asleep, which was both comforting and worrisome. Did it mean Lisa would wake up feeling recovered? Or that she was so weak she was still completely knocked out?

In any case, Jean felt like she needed to lighten Lisa's weight for a while; she carefully got up from bed without disturbing her much and left her sleeping while she went to prepare breakfast. While she waited for the water to boil and the bread to toast, she wrote two notes, one for Kaeya and the other for the library staff, and when she heard Amber knocking on the door for their morning run, she excused herself and asked her to deliver both notes.

Once she had finished preparing breakfast, she went to check on Lisa again and found her barely waking up.

—Lisa?— she called her. When the witch moved her head to look at her, she smiled and said —Good morning, Love.

—Jean…—. It sounded more like a groaning, she felt weak but was still trying to sit, and her eyes were sore so she couldn't see much. —It's… What time… is it?— she asked, her voice barely audible.

Jean went to her side and sat next to her, caressing her hair away from her face.

—A little late, but don't worry— Jean answered. —Breakfast is ready. Can you get up? Or would you rather I bring you breakfast here?

Lisa mumbled something incomprehensible and finally sat up. Jean giggled and kissed her forehead.

A couple of minutes later, they were both at the table eating toasts, Lisa with a cup of tea and Jean with a mug of coffee.

—Hm…— Lisa hummed. —Thank you, Sweetheart— she said, a bit more awake. Her expression was still tired, but she felt much better than earlier. —Now… Why don't you tell me who convinced you to take the day off?— she teased her.

Jean sipped her coffee to cover her blush. When she lowered the cup, she shyly kept her sight lowered.

—I… I decided to stay, and make sure you could stay home too— she answered. —So… today, I left Kaeya to cover for me and made sure the library staff would handle everything

for you too.

Lisa put her tea down and looked at Jean perplexed. For the restless Acting Grand Master to have taken such a decision, her state since last night must have been even worse than imagined.

—Did… Did I scare you that much?— Lisa asked, a bit embarrassed, while finishing her toast.

She didn't want to admit it, but finally said —I wasn't scared *of* you, just *for* you. The only time I saw you deploy so much electro power… well, you know when it was, and I know you were in control then, but yesterday you were… unhinged.

The witch remembered, that rainy afternoon would forever stay in her memory. Especially since she thought she had lost Jean permanently, yet it was the moment she won the Grand Master's unconditional love.

—I remember, yes— Lisa admitted. —And you're right. Yesterday was different for many reasons.

It was a different time back then, when Lisa felt more confident and didn't care if people feared her as much as the hilichurls… She had seen Jean and her companions on patrol and stayed nearby, curious about how the new Grand Master would perform now that Varka had left the city. Yet when the storm began and the enemies surrounded them, the witch couldn't stand idle and watch; her lightnings crackled around her as she approached the mob, and thanks to the rain, they quickly got shocked simultaneously. But it wasn't enough, and Jean was still in the middle of the assault, giving her companions time to escape. Lisa noticed a Cryo Abyss Mage had just appeared next to her and the witch’s senses shut down: she wouldn't hear, feel, or perceive in any way her surroundings, only the important parts were highlighted in her mind. And her lightning struck true, frying all remaining enemies.

—You know…— Jean suddenly said, waking Lisa from her remembrance. —That time, when I saw you coming closer, surrounded by lightning, for an instant I feared you, yes, but when you were close enough, I could only admire you— she told her.

Jean was barely adjusting to her new position back then, and part of her adjustment was figuring out just who to trust within the Knights; either because their power or their knowledge were above hers, she needed to be sure she would always make the best decisions for those she sent to patrol or scout. And the witch had been the biggest enigma, yet she couldn’t begin to imagine she had such power… As soon as all the enemies around them were defeated, Jean used her anemo power to heal them both, just in case. Lisa knelt next to Jean, her expression apologetic, no trace of the carefree librarian who kept avoiding her questions. This was the real Lisa, surrendered in front of her. And right then, Jean only wanted to comfort the witch, thank her, make sure she was alright, while all Lisa needed was the small gesture of being allowed to rest on Jean's lap while her anemo power healed them.

—Would you believe me if I told you I thought you'd see me as a monster?— Lisa asked her.

—You saved my life, Lisa…

—With an insane amount of power and in the cruelest way— she interrupted.

—It's not like that Abyss mage would have gone if you kindly asked him— Jean replied, mockingly.

—Jean… Tell me the truth: if the other knights, if any of the other captains, had seen that… how would they have reacted?— Lisa asked. —Or rather, why didn't you run away from me? —. Before Jean could answer, Lisa added —And I swear, if you say you were already in love with me, I *will* walk out of the house right now.

Jean couldn't help giggling at the obvious teasing behind her "threat".

—No, well… I'm not entirely sure why, but… like I said, I couldn't really fear you, only admire how skilled and fearless you were right then— she answered. —I let you rest on my lap because I couldn't find the words to have you know you could trust me and… I wasn't really sure what state you were in, but I didn't want you to flee when you could be hurt, and right after having saved me and my company.

They both sighed at the same time, silently finished their breakfast, and after cleaning the table and washing the dishes, Lisa just hugged Jean and held her between her arms. She needed to feel her closeness.

—Thank you, Jean— Lisa muttered. —For giving me a chance.

Instead of answering, Jean cupped her face and tenderly kissed her.

City of Mondstadt, Library of the Knights of Favonius, afternoon :

After three days, the situation wasn’t any better for the electro users but, finally, they all had resumed their daily activities. Both Fischl and Razor kept accompanying Bennett and Amber on their patrolling and less dangerous commissions, and though Razor was mostly staying at Wolvendom, he would periodically visit Mond, as he and his friends kept coming up with ideas to replace his Lightning Fang. This time, he brought Lisa some lightning crystals that Bennett had collected, and the witch was trying to infuse his claymore with their power.

—Excuse us— Amber's voice suddenly interrupted. Lisa and Razor looked back at the door and saw Amber come in, followed by Fischl and Jean. —A letter from Lumine just arrived— she announced.

—Oh, any news?— Lisa asked, interested.

—The expected…— Amber sighed. —When she arrived, she tried to resonate with electro at one of the Statues of the Seven, as she did here and in Liyue, but it didn’t work. So, the archon must be restricting the electro power in all of Teyvat.

—That’s… how is it even possible?— Lisa wondered.

—There should be more gods related to electro, right? How can the archon hold absolute power over the element?— Jean asked.

—Apparently, she arrived at the same conclusion— Amber replied. —She says she will be searching for any other divinity in Inazuma, and keep collecting information about the archon. There must be records on how she achieved so much power, right?

—Well, that could be true, as long as anyone who could record how that happened ever managed to actually publish it— Lisa commented. —You saw the ambassador, the word of the Bakufu is law. And, if there are rebels in Inazuma, they are in grave danger and wouldn't dare publish their knowledge to avoid getting caught.

—Maybe Lumine can help the rebels and get information in exchange— Amber suggested. Then, she looked at Fischl and asked her —Wanna tell them what you said earlier?

Fischl cleared her throat, and began —One has felt the dangers of Inazuma surrounding the other-worldly traveler, but one has faith in her prowess and cunning—. She seemed to be feeling better and Lisa couldn't help smiling at the thought. —One can feel there are opposing forces clashing in those lands, and it is the traveler who may decide the result, if she can guide the rebellious.

Still in her arms, Oz translated —Mein Fräulen knows the traveler will find help to face the Archon.

Lisa hummed and closed her arms in front of her chest, her expression serious.

—Mona told us the best course of action was diplomacy, even if it was difficult, so if Lumine can make use of the rebellion's support to have a chance at diplomatically fixing this matter, then any conflict may be avoided— she reflected.

—So we can only wait, right?— Jean said.

—Will she… be safe?— Razor asked, clearly referring to Lumine.

Lisa smiled and assured him —Of course, Little Wolfie. She's very capable.

City of Mondstadt, Grand Master Jean's residency, afternoon :

Jean and Lisa arrived home after being practically kicked out of their workplaces. Kaeya convinced some knights and the library's staff to handle everything for the remainder of the day so the women could rest. He had been feeling useless since he couldn't help with the visions' dilemma, and would try to give them a respite at least every few days.

—Well, you can't say they don't care about us— Lisa commented with a giggle. —They must have made such an effort to take everything off our backs…

—I didn't want that, I'd rather be distracted with work, you know?— Jean replied.

Lisa took a seat at the table and looked at the woman pacing back and forth in front of her.

—I know, Dear, but you should also relax. These days have been stressful for all of us…

—I should go to the backyard and train…— Jean decided, ignoring Lisa.

The witch rolled her eyes and gave up on trying to convince her. For a couple of hours, she sat outside on a bench, reading a book while Jean practiced her swordfight; and sometimes looked up, enjoying the view. The woman was restless, she just kept repeating the same stances over and over again.

—Hey, Jean— Lisa called her. When she finally put her sword down and looked back at her, the witch asked —Why don't you put that energy into something a little more useful?

Almost offended, Jean answered —Practice *is* useful!

Lisa stood up, leaving her book on the bench, and walked towards her, insisting —Please, your skill can't possibly get better, why not make something else with so much stamina?

—Like what?

Lisa brushed Jean's hair aside and suggested, with a lowered tone, —Well, you could cook your delicious pizza for me…

Jean felt her face reddening and looked away, clearing her throat.

—Well, cooking doesn't sound bad— she admitted. —But I should take a shower first.

Lisa giggled and nodded.

As agreed, Jean freshened up and began preparing the dough for the pizza with Lisa’s help. However, they made more than necessary and had enough for three pizzas.

—I don't think we can eat this much before they go to waste— Jean commented, after getting the third tray inside the oven.

From her seat at the table, Lisa suggested —Why don't we invite the kids for dinner? I'm sure they will enjoy the food and we can see how they are holding up.

Jean looked back at her, gladly surprised by Lisa's kindness.

—You're really worried about them, aren't you?

—Jean, I'm a full grown-up yet I'm barely coping and you know it— she answered nonchalantly.

—Yes, yes… fine. I'll go invite them— Jean accepted.

—Oh no, please allow me; you finish cooking, alright?

Without another word, Lisa left and came back almost half an hour later, accompanied by Razor, Fischl, Bennett, and Amber.

Hours later, the pizzas were gone but the table talk was still on. Jean couldn't remember the last time she had shared such a lively dinner, but she was glad to see the kids enjoy themselves as if nothing had happened; without disturbing them, she picked up the dishes and took them away. The four seemed to have engaged in a heated -but friendly- discussion about their own cooking skills, so Lisa left the table too and joined Jean to help her.

—It was a good idea— she admitted. —They do seem much better, but… Are you feeling better? I keep forgetting to ask…

—I am— the witch interrupted her.

—I meant… I keep forgetting to ask how you managed to summon the electro energy the other day, and how it affected you— Jean clarified. She finished with the dishes and turned to face Lisa. —I may not know that much about the subject, but I'm sure it wasn't supposed to happen.

She looked away, instinctively reaching up to where her vision used to hang on her collar.

—In simple terms… Let's say we have like a goblet within us from where we draw elemental energy, and the function of the vision is to connect us to that energy easily, like a faucet that allows us to use it— Lisa tried to explain. —It's not really like that, but, for reference… So, what happened to us is that we can no longer open that faucet or, if we do, we'll just empty our reservoir of energy which will no longer replenish. That's why Oz is still there; while Fischl has some electro energy within her, he will exist, and the prisms I've been giving her keep her reservoir from emptying faster than Razor's or mine. Ah- actually, forget that, mine's basically empty, I guess.

—Lisa…

—Don't worry, Jean, it's really fine— she insisted.

—Please, Lisa—. She held her hands and closed the distance. —You don't have to pretend you're alright if you aren't; I'll worry all the same, and I'd rather be able to comfort you if you need it.

Lisa hugged her tightly and sighed. Looking back at the children, she let out a smile and took a deep breath. That was all the comfort she needed from Jean.

City of Mondstadt, Lisa's workshop, morning :

Later that week, after Jean brought her more Lightning Prisms, Lisa took them to her lab, looking for a way to improve their efficiency; they were barely helping Oz, and it was becoming increasingly difficult to get them. Lately, even Bennett and Mona had offered their help to acquire them, but what Lisa feared was the disappearance of the Electro Hypostases

themselves. They had no idea how Baal's inhibition of the electro energy could affect the wildlife, and hunting down Hypostases couldn't help.

—If there was a way to imitate the core effect, or at least increase its lifespan…— the witch was muttering, unaware of who had just walked in. A sudden crash startled her and she turned around to find Sucrose cleaning up a broken vial. —Oh my, when did you walk in?

—I-I'm so sorry, miss Lisa, I didn't mean to interrupt your pondering.

—Oh, don't worry, Cutie; I was just thinking aloud— she assured her. —However, would you mind helping me a little with your insight? I swear I've given this so much thought… Something must be right in front of me yet I'm not seeing it— Lisa asked her.

Flustered at the sudden request, Sucrose stared at her for a minute before accepting. She approached the desk where Lisa had her notes spread out along with a couple of prisms for examination, she skimmed through the notes, pushing her glasses back every now and again, and finally gave her opinion.

—Well, we know these prisms are what the Hypostases use to heal themselves when they are about to collapse and, in a way, they work like visions because they channel nearby elemental energy— she began, her eyes fixed on the desk as she wouldn't dare look directly at Lisa, especially with the witch's full attention on her. —So, that means they also have a limit, and that the lack of protection, something like the glass encasing the visions, is what makes them so ephemeral.

—Hm… An encasing of some type should preserve the prisms for longer— Lisa reflected. —Well, that was a very good observation, Dear. Thank you very much.

—A-a pleasure to help, miss Lisa.

After Sucrose left, taking with her a couple of vials full of shimmering liquids, the witch searched the place for something she could use. It had to be translucent, after all, these prisms were similar to normal ones, they just don't separate light but rather channel energy; however she couldn't fit them inside a vial or ampule, she needed something wider.

Hours later, Lisa had finally found a suitable case for the prisms; she called Noelle and gave her a fabric bag full of the Lightning Prisms and a crystal case, with a note to be delivered to Fischl, explaining she should place the prism in use within that container to make sure it lasted longer.

Lisa stayed at the workshop, half-asleep herself yet restless her mind, and completely lost track of time. A knock on the door brought her back to her senses and Amber came in when she answered.

—Miss Lisa?— she asked. —Ah… You *are* here. We were worried.

—Worried?— she repeated, with a tired smile. —My… Don't tell me you all thought I was lost in the wilderness or something.

Amber laughed nervously.

—Well, I may have thought so.

Lisa laughed daintily and replied —Oh, how sweet. But worry not, Cutie, I wouldn't go too far, I'd rather stay here reading.

—I should have known— she admitted. —It's just that you were gone the whole day and you weren't in the library…

—Wait, what time is it?

—Eh… Ten at night?— Amber answered, fearing Lisa's reaction.

The witch didn't answer. She stood up, tidied the desk, and walked out with Amber, closing the workshop behind her.

City of Mondstadt, restricted section of the Library of the Knights of Favonius, afternoon :

Another week ended, a new letter from Lumine arrived, and the news from Inazuma weren't encouraging. In simple terms, she still had to figure out a way to speak with Baal. She had also mentioned the people in Inazuma were clueless about the waned visions, so Lisa felt the need to investigate for herself.

After her tea with Jean, she went straight to the restricted section of the library and quickly checked the names in the bookshelves, grabbing every book she considered potentially useful. Hours later, she was still going through them, several of them at the same time. Lisa used a spell to open seven different books, and held them levitating around her; the pages turned as a bright light went through their lines, and the same light was present in the witch's eyes as if letting her read every book at the same time with impossible speed.

This was the peculiar scene Albedo walked into. It took him a minute too long to understand what he was seeing, but it was too late to walk away; she had already noticed him. The light receded from Lisa's eyes, the books closed and drifted back to their places in the bookshelves, and when she looked at him, her expression was neuter, concealing any trace of annoyance she could have felt at the interruption.

—Afternoon, Albedo— she said. —I recall asking you to inform me before coming down here— she reminded him.

—Apologies, miss Lisa, but I couldn't find you. I only walked in because I saw light coming from the inside— he explained himself. —Am I right to think you are investigating what happened to the visions?

Lisa nodded and walked to a nearby desk to take a seat. Albedo approached the desk and sat in front of her.

—This particular matter remains unanswered, and I have the feeling I can uncover what was done to them— she finally replied.

—Well… I've been meaning to share with you what I found out about the ambassador, only confirmed a few days ago to be related to the visions— he said. —I actually came down from Dragonspine while he was still in the city. And I observed him for days as I didn't know what was unsettling me about him.

Lisa's interest was clearly picked and she leaned on the desk.

—Well, master Alchemist, don't keep me waiting.

—I came to notice he went to key locations in Mondstadt, also gathered rare ingredients, and a day before he left, he checked all the places he had been to— Albedo began. —I may be more familiar with alchemy than magic and spells, but I can recognize complex spells like those. The City of Mondstadt is the epicenter of our region, energetically speaking, and I realized he had done something to affect the whole of Mondstadt but I couldn't prove it was what dulled the visions.

—So, the Electro Archon wasn't the one who severed our connection to the visions?— Lisa asked.

—She did, but for her power to reach all of Teyvat, she must have made use of whatever the ambassadors did so her spell would resonate everywhere— Albedo replied. —We know the visions only get dull like that when the owner of the vision dies, so she probably used some spell to make the visions believe you're all dead already.

Lisa nodded and said —I have been investigating metaphysics manipulation spells, something that could cause such an illusion on the world's energy.

Albedo rested his head on his hands and commented —So she must have given the ambassadors the order to place those spells and then created the illusion spell herself. This means that, eventually, physics will adjust to metaphysics—. After a short pause, he asked her —How will you tell her? You know you have to…

Lisa looked at Albedo, his expression was neutral as usual, but didn't answer him. She just stood up, opened the door, and after a moment of hesitation, left the room.

Windwail Highland, Outskirts of Springvale, past midnight :

It's very late in the night and Lisa is still brushing the sleep off of her eyes, trying to find Jean in the wilderness. Only a few minutes before, she had woken up suddenly, scared of a nightmare she couldn't remember, only to find herself alone in bed. On other occasions, she'd find at least a note from Jean telling her there was an emergency and she had to leave, but this time there was none, so the witch got dressed as quickly as she could and let her magic guide her to Jean's general location. When she blinked there, she recognized the road to

Springvale and once again let her magic find Jean. She just wanted to see she was alright and would then head back, there wasn't much she could do.

—And a storm is brewing…— she noticed, when the light of the moon suddenly faded. She kept walking, faster now that she could hear the clattering of armor along with incomprehensible chatting, and soon found Jean with a handful of knights. —Ah, there you are…— she sighed, not daring to advance any further.

She felt sore and needed to get back to sleep, and now that she was sure Jean at least had some backup, worry couldn't keep her awake. However, she had barely turned around when she heard the sudden outcry of a group of Hilicurls close by. As soon as she saw the archers, she blinked out of the way of their pyro-infused arrows, only to appear almost next to a hilichurl with a shield, and another one who had just dug out a pyro slime.

The moment she blinked a few meters away, she heard Jean's voice screaming —Charge!

The witch sighed and muttered —Oh thanks… that was getting annoying.

She and her knights dealt with the hilichurls quickly, then Jean rushed to Lisa as soon as she could, to make sure she wasn't injured.

—For Barbatos! Lisa, what were you doing here?— she asked her, noticeably worried.

—Ah, don't worry Jean— she replied casually. —I got anxious when I woke up and you weren't there, but now I was about to leave as I saw you have back up— she explained.

—Ah…— Jean sighed. —Right, I had to run, I'm sorry.

—It's fine, alright? I'll just head back— Lisa insisted.

—Lisa, please stop putting yourself in harm's way, alright?— Jean asked her. She then hugged her and muttered —We still have to get married, remember?

Lisa giggled as Jean let go of her and assured her —No need to worry, Jean. My magic is still here, I can blink away from danger.

Jean just looked away and insisted —Just… stay safe, for me. Will you?

Lisa gently caressed Jean's cheek and kissed her forehead before finally blinking back to their home.

The Grand Master joined her knights and they went back to tracking down the suspicious Fatui lurking around Springvale. Behind her, she could hear how they discussed the unexpected apparition of Lisa.

—I'm actually surprised. I've seen her fight a few times but it never lasted long, one strike and that was it. Seeing her have to escape and dodge is…

—"Scape and dodge"? Don't say it like it's a bad thing. I'd give anything to be able to just blink away like that.

—Well yes, but… think about it: it's so strange that she can't use electro anymore.

—If you're hoping she won't try to electrocute you for not returning books in time, let me tell you that woman will find the way to do it anyway if you dare lose a book.

The third knight who chimed into their conversation was probably trying to lighten the mood but, for Jean, it felt almost disrespectful.

—Enough! You shouldn't talk about any member of the Knights that way. Even if said person is a clerk, you're expected to refer to everyone within our ranks with the utmost respect— Jean stated.

The knights apologized and kept silent the rest of the mission. It didn't take them much longer to find the Fatui that had been reported to be suspiciously lurking around Springvale, but it turned out to be a "researcher" looking for a rare species of Luminescent Grass; Jean decided to give him a warning and suggested him to ask their resident alchemists and herbalists for help with his research.

Clearly exhausted but unwilling to leave her job half-done, she decided to stop by the headquarters to write her report, but Captain Kaeya found her before she could leave, and insisted she allow him to handle the next day and take a rest. After all, he had already heard about Lisa showing up so, along with his smooth-talk, it didn't take long to convince Jean to accept the day off.

City of Mondstadt, Grand Master Jean's residency, afternoon :

When Jean rose that morning and failed to wake Lisa up before noon, she realized it was actually a blessing to have Kaeya cover for her again. She was still uncomfortable with leaving her job like that, but she feared she would regret not being there to help Lisa. It was getting noticeably harder to wake her up, but once the witch was awake, she usually mustered enough energy to function as usual.

—Ah… that was delicious, but really, you shouldn't have— Jean insisted.

Lisa felt so bad for waking up so late that she decided to cook lunch and made pasta with her own special touch. She was sure this day off would have Jean restless and wanting to train later, so that lunch would actually fit her needs.

—It was no big deal, Love. I actually missed cooking this recipe— she answered, sipping a cup of tea.

About an hour after lunch, Jean went to their room for a moment before coming back out wearing comfortable slacks and a loose shirt under a tight stomacher. Lisa followed her every move with her eyes and when she saw her grab her sword, the witch followed her outside. In the backyard, Jean began stretching as usual while Lisa finished her tea; seeing her knight training was always enticing, but this time it gave her an idea.

—Eh? What are you doing?— Jean asked when she saw Lisa approach her.

—Well, Love, you just reminded me a bit of last night, and I think I should prove to you I'm not completely defenseless— she replied, gently grabbing Jean's chin to raise her sight to her. —So, what do you say? Try catching me, make your best effort—. She winked and giggled before concluding —If you can't catch me, neither can the hilichurls.

The witch suddenly let go of Jean's face, their mouths barely a palm away, and suddenly blinked a few meters away from her, appearing next to a tree on the back of the yard.

Excited by the challenge, she grabbed her blunt training word and ran after Lisa. Every time she blinked, Jean would pay attention to her eyes, guessing the general direction in which she should move, and used her anemo mostly to speed herself up, and only once to try and pull Lisa her way. However, every time Jean was about to grab her or at least brush her with the tip of her sword, the witch was already gone. Time and again, she blinked away from her sword's way, just out of her reach, with enough time to tease Jean, mention how she was sweating and out of breath already, and even comment how she actually looked quite tempting like that.

Finally, Jean staggered and had to rest her body against the tree on the back of their garden. She was breathing heavily and had begun feeling dizzy.

—Ah… ah… I don't… think… I can… go on…— she admitted, between gasps.

Lisa crossed her arms in front of her chest and with teasing smugness said —Well? Not bad for being "defenseless", right?

Jean just leaned against the tree trunk and groaned.

—I may have pulled a few muscles just now— she complained, her breath finally easier.

—Oh, Dear…— Lisa whispered and went to kneel by Jean's side. —You just need rest, Love.

—Oh, do I?— Jean asked, cupping Lisa's face. —Maybe you're right but…—, she suddenly wrapped her arms around Lisa and pulled her into a kiss, dipping Lisa over her lap. —Mhmm… I think I win.

Lisa opened her eyes to find Jean staring at her with a playful and loving expression and felt her own soften.

—Well played, my knight— Lisa said, brushing a lock of Jean's hair behind her ear. —But now you better live up to your promise— she reminded her.

Jean kissed her briefly and held her on her lap while asking —Which promise?

Lisa pretended indignation but it wasn't long before she burst out laughing.

—Fine, I don't think I can come up with any plausible lie in such a short time but… — Lisa admitted, interrupting herself only to kiss Jean again, —… what do you say? Should we

freshen up and continue back in the bedroom?

Jean nodded and kissed Lisa over and over again, as if she couldn't get enough of the witch. After a moment, Lisa blinked away and Jean gathered all her training gear before walking back into the house. She entered the bedroom while taking off her stomacher, only to hear water already running in the bathroom. When she walked in, she couldn't hide her astonishment.

—You…

—Yes, Darling?

Lisa's tone and her dainty giggle perfectly matched the scene in front of Jean. The witch was still filling the bathtub with steaming water, but the room was already foggy, and she was sitting inside. Lisa was laying against the back of the tub, her legs hanging from the border as she idly moved them back and forth. Her inviting smile and intense eyes fixed on Jean, expecting.

—Now you're just torturing my poor heart— Jean finally said.

—Oh, am I?— Lisa laughed. —Maybe if you got out of those… you and your heart could come and enjoy.

As suggested, Jean quickly removed her clothes and approached Lisa. However, before getting in, Jean stood behind her, cupped the witch's face, tilting her head back, and tenderly kissed her.

—Lisa…

—Oh, get in, already— she interrupted her. —You're all sweaty, let me clean you up.

—Right— Jean sighed, laughing a little. —Wouldn't want to keep you waiting.

Jean stepped into the bathtub slowly; feeling the warm water gave her goosebumps which faded as soon as the rest of her body sank next to Lisa. The witch closed the faucet, moved her hands around the water to stir it, her fingers leaving a trail of bubbles, and a sweet fragrance filled the bathroom. Jean looked at Lisa and kissed her as their arms wrapped around each other. The next moment, she had pulled the witch on top of her, they were still kissing as if their lives depended on it, while their hands began caressing each other. Lisa seemed to actually be trying to wash away the sweat from her body, while Jean only placed her hands right under the witch's buttcheeks, holding her in place.

When Lisa let go of her, Jean noticed the witch seems to have some spell on her hands to produce soap with her touch; part of her found the gesture really endearing, but she couldn't completely ignore the way Lisa managed to make it even more erotic than it had to be. Still, she adored and admired her magic so much. The next moment, Lisa stood up in front of Jean and made a show of washing her body, simply caressing her skin with her hands.

On instinct, Jean looked away blushing, to which Lisa said —You're allowed to watch, Love.

When she looked at Lisa again, the witch noticed she had left her speechless but took it a step further, blowing a kiss as her hands rubbed her own boobs. Jean felt her throat completely dry and reached up to drag Lisa back underwater.

It took them a few more minutes to finally get out of the tub and dry themselves, but they wouldn't let go of each other and soon Jean was carrying Lisa to bed.

—Oh my… I never tire of your strength— Lisa whispered.

Jean laid her down on the mattress and crawled on top of her as she asked —Oh really? What do you like about my strength?

Lisa's lips curled in a knowing smile before answering —Oh, you know: I like… how you can handle several enemies on your own—. One of her hands reached up to trace her jawline as she continued —But I like it more when you pick me up like I weigh nothing at all… which lets you rail me just anywhere.

—Lisa, I said we're not making out at the library again— Jean answered, a bit too serious. —We barely managed to keep that bookshelf from falling last time.

Lisa laughed wholeheartedly and countered —Then I suppose we can still make out in your office—. Her hands wrapped around Jean's neck to help her reach up and brush her lips teasingly. —There's nothing to accidentally topple over, and the sofas are very comfortable.

—You…

The witch interrupted her with a kiss and bit her lower lip softly. Jean held Lisa's back and sat on her lap. Her hands wandered down her back while the witch played with her hair and kissed her deeply. When Jean's hands reached her butt, she lifted Lisa's right thigh over her left and then wrapped her legs tightly around the witch, pressing their bodies together.

—Ah… Jean…— Lisa gasped.

—I love you— Jean blurted out, before starting to kiss Lisa's neck intently.

—I… love… you too… my knight— the witch answered, breathless, holding Jean's back with all her strength to press their bodies together as much as possible.

Both women had begun the day so worried, and said worries always followed them relentlessly. But when they were enjoying each other like that, the rest of the world would just vanish, their troubles with it, and as long as they had each other, they could always have these moments of rest.

City of Mondstadt, Favonius Headquarters, afternoon :

Two weeks after Lumine left for Inazuma, her news were still disappointing. The Knights and the Adventurers Guild made their best efforts to keep daily life uneventful for Lisa, Razor, and Fischl, but little by little, they noticed how the loss of their vision was affecting them.

During the last few days, many of the captains who had been deployed before the ambassador's arrival at Mond were back in the city. In the afternoon, Lisa went to Jean's office for their afternoon tea, and they received captain Eula who joined them for a cup as she usually does when she's back in the city.

—I really missed so much in three weeks— Eula commented, after hearing everything from them. She took a sip, noticeably avoiding Lisa's sight, which she noticed. —And are you sure this shouldn't be seen as an attack on Mondstadt?

Before Jean could actually answer, Lisa stopped her with a gesture and said —Being away when this happened doesn't make you guilty, and no. This can't be considered an attack, so don't start looking for reasons to retaliate.

Lisa seemed to have completely guessed Eula's intentions now that she learned what happened, so she decided to be straightforward.

—Then I will formally ask to be deployed to Inazuma. Recognizance wouldn't be a threat for…

—Absolutely not— Jean interrupted Eula. —The situation is delicate, even if you got to the borders you have no reasons to be let in. What is more, we don't know how it could affect everything the Honorary Knight has been doing to solve this diplomatically, so it's a risk we can't take.

—Ah… Right. I should trust her more. The Honorary knight proved to be a quick learner and has a talent for blending in with the enemy— Eula reminded herself. Then she finished her tea and suddenly recalled —Ah, before I forget. I suppose congratulations are in order.

Lisa covered her mouth with one hand to hold back a laugh as Jean's face reddened.

—What? How do you know already?— Jean blurted out, surprised and slightly embarrassed.

—Captain Kaeya told me.

Lisa giggled and replied —As expected. And thank you, Dear.

The witch kept drinking her tea while Jean cleared her throat to properly thank her too. She noticed Eula seemed to be concerned about something, her attention focused but pretending she wasn't particularly interested in anything; while, looking back at Lisa, Jean had the feeling she had noticed it too but was purposely letting it slide instead of pressing the matter or teasing her to skillfully pry the information out of Eula.

A knock on the door interrupted them and Lisa stepped out for a moment to talk with Noelle. Once the door closed, Eula looked at Jean with a serious expression.

—Please, Master Jean, be honest. What is happening to miss Lisa?— she asked. Jean let out a small smile, noticing she really cared, and Eula quickly added —I can't possibly let some foreigners destroy the Knights of Favonius, how else will I take my vengeance on you?

Jean's smile only widened as she shook her head, lowering her sight to her cup of tea.

—I want to say she's doing fine but… it's clearly difficult— she admitted. —She's getting weaker as days pass by, even waking her up is almost impossible until around noon, so she's been working half her usual shift. And the same is happening to both, Razor and Fischl; I mean, Lisa has always been less energetic, but this means it's clearly connected to the waned visions— Jean explained. —I've been told Amber was visiting Fischl periodically, taking her food, sometimes the prisms Lisa sends her, and the last few days she could barely wake her up to at least have lunch. While Razor no longer comes to Mond, his friends go and visit him sometimes but he's mostly asleep between the wolves.

Eula sighed and asked, once again, —Please, Acting Grand Master, allow me to take my troupe to Inazuma. This is unacceptable.

—I will not deploy you again for now. We can't afford to accidentally interfere with the Honorary Knight's plan. Besides… I need all available captains here in case of unforeseen circumstances— Jean replied. —We have relied too much on Lisa's flexibility to fix unexpected matters, and now we can't anymore.

Eula served herself more tea and said —Of course, it would be dangerous to send her, even as a backup, because she can't protect herself now.

Jean put down her cup and suggested —You better don't let her hear you—. After pouring herself another cup of tea, she finally admitted —But I'm concerned about the same… A few days ago, she got attacked at night near Springvale. She was looking for me, I couldn't leave her a note to let her know I was handling an emergency commission, and even though she didn't stay more than a couple of minutes, a handful of hilichurls managed to attack her— Jean recounted. Eula stared at her, surprised, but didn't comment. —She insists her magic can keep her safe. She can't attack them but can avoid them, blink away from their way…

—Blink away? You mean… like how the Abyss Mages blink at will? She wouldn't be able to escape them since they can always keep following her with the same technique— Eula stated, sure she had taken every factor into consideration.

They both sighed and silently drank their teas for a moment before Lisa came back.

—I hope you two left some for me— she said as she took her seat.

—What was that? You were away so long— Jean pointed out.

—Ah, it was nothing, really— she brushed it off. —I just had to make sure Noelle understood my request, worry not— she added, as she poured herself more tea. —Now tell me, Eula, any news?— she asked, as if nothing had happened.

City of Mondstadt, Library of the Knights of Favonius, late night :

The following days, Lisa felt more tired and almost heavier, but she couldn't stop looking into possible ways to counter the archon's spell on the visions, or at least, find a way to keep the physical world from adjusting to the metaphysical plane.

—Another unprecedented case, huh?— she mumbled. —I can't believe I actually…— she scolded herself for such a silly comparison. This was not the same. Even losing her vision had felt like it was equal to death, but now she's sure it was an exaggeration. She just shouldn't compare both situations. —I need to find a solution… I could maybe get some help but… No, it would probably be useless— she kept talking to herself.

The sudden bang of the library door being opened abruptly startled the witch, who looked up instantly only to see Jean barging in, furious, followed by Kaeya and Albedo.

—You better have a great explanation, Lisa, or I swear I'm burning every single book you possess!— Jean threatened her.

Lisa stared at her, a bit astonished at her words, then looked back at Albedo and Kaeya. The witch glared at the alchemist with such an expression that Kaeya took a step away from him, as if expecting a bolt of lightning to suddenly strike him down.

—So he told you…— Lisa mumbled. However, she tried to keep her usual demeanor and simply said —Well, Dear, if you think my books are my most precious possessions, I'm sorry to say you need to refresh your information. You can't threaten me with that, I already lost the most precious thing to me after you.

At first, it caught Jean off guard. Lisa's words were true, but she wasn't expecting them.

—Don't deflect.

—Fine— Lisa finally let out. —If you want to know why I didn't tell you what is going to happen to us as a consequence of how our visions were deactivated… I suppose I could excuse myself saying there wasn't a good moment to breach the subject, or that I didn't want to worry you, or that I'm trying to fix it and would have preferred it if you never knew— Lisa began. Then she looked away and finally confessed —But, in reality, I didn't say a thing because it would change nothing from this situation, you are already worried enough, and to have you freaking out for the imminence of our…— Lisa interrupted herself and looked back at Jean. She walked out of her desk and stepped into Jean's personal space while asking, almost in an accusing way, —Why would you want to know such a grim thing? Or rather, how will you keep this from the kids? Or do you think your expression alone won't let them know something is very wrong, worse than the vision's waning?

—Lisa…

—No, Jean. I'm sorry but I can't express how much I tried to make sure things wouldn't get out of control, so it is *I* who will now ask mister Albedo for a very good reason for disclosing this information— she interrupted her, and turned around to look at Albedo when she said his name.

Jean stood still, almost frozen, next to Lisa; she understood the reasoning behind her actions, but couldn't help feeling betrayed.

—It was an accident, miss Lisa, I swear— he replied calmly. —I thought you had already told her, so after coming from Wolvendom I went to update Master Jean on Razor's state and

made it clear he has little time— he explained. —And Captain Kaeya was there too, apparently because Fischl had barely woken up a couple of minutes the last few days.

Lisa felt her chest tighten at that, but she still believed it was the wrong move to make.

—None of you speak a word of this— Lisa stated. She seemed to be making a huge effort to keep herself calm. —They don't need to know this, so don't ever let Amber, Bennett, or even Klee hear about this. If the subject comes up, they are getting weaker, they have less energy, but do not mention anything else— she clarified. —Please…

Jean placed a hand on her shoulder and Lisa looked at her with a pained expression.

—If we really can't do anything else, then we can only place our faith in the Honorary Knight to solve this from the root— Jean told her. —Maybe she can appeal to the Electro Archon's good will, maybe she doesn't even know this is happening and will reverse it once Lumine explains it to her. As for the kids, I believe for now Barbatos will keep them safe.

Lisa shook her head while looking down, clearly skeptical. She took a step back and sat on top of her desk. The witch looked into Jean's eyes, it was clear she meant it, which hurt Lisa even more for what she had to say.

—I'm sorry Jean, but I don't think the gods care for us at all— she began. —You may put all your trust in him… however, we both know he didn't care either—. Her tone was gentle yet severe enough to get her message across. —I know you've wondered why he didn't help me with all the citizenship stuff, which he could have solved with a word— she told her, making Jean look away embarrassed. —But it's fine, I'd rather be able to fix my own problems. Nevertheless, we have to admit we mean nothing to the gods, they won't care for some humans dying. After all, we were never meant to last more than a breath compared to their eternity.

—But… he *has* taken care of Mondstadt's people, you know it…

—No, Dear, he just supported an already existing rebellion, it was all the people and he wasn't even powerful enough at the time to try to keep them safe. And *you* know it, because you told me about his humble origins— Lisa interrupted.

—But he's more powerful now, and he faced Durin to keep us safe…

—No, he sent his friend to face him, gave him the strength and support, but that was it; he left us on our own for five hundred years, and couldn't even stop Dvalin on his own when the Abyss controlled him— she reminded her. However she refrained from continuing and instead said —It's okay, Dear, I don't mean to slander the Anemo Archon but I need you to understand these facts. It has always been like that, Jean; you can place your faith and trust on Barbatos, but the truth is… the world of the gods wouldn't care for us. They don't intend to.

With a sigh, the witch left her desk and walked out of the library, leaving the Knights to ponder.

—With all due respect—, Kaeya said, looking at Jean, —I have to agree with miss Lisa.

—I don't like what I'm about to say but… it is true that the seven archons could have solved this between themselves as soon as their people with electro visions lost their power— Albedo commented. —Maybe they have other reasons to stay away from Baal's business, but we can't deny it… they could have solved this from the very first moment.

Jean closed her eyes and lowered her head. It was all too much for her: feeling powerless in such a situation was internally consuming her, yet she felt it was selfish to feel sorry for herself when it was them who were tied to Baal's will.

Yet that night, Jean prayed to Barbatos for hours before falling asleep; she couldn't help herself and let out everything on her chest, mentioning how she couldn't just see them slowly fall into an eternal sleep, yet couldn't actually do anything for them, and emphasizing how she still trusts he'd protect them, even Lisa, despite her skepticism.

City of Mondstadt, hall of the Favonius Headquarters, afternoon :

Jean had been unfocused all day. Since learning about the imminent fate of the electro users, she had been almost unable to keep her usual efficiency. And the fact that, somehow, Lisa kept going to work, that she even *wants* to go to work, kept her on edge all day. The witch was right, her behavior wouldn't let her hide her concern, and now she seemed to treat Lisa like some fragile crystal, every detail a potential crack: if she yawned more than usual, if she woke up even a minute later than the previous day, if she walked slower than normal, everything would set off an alarm on Jean's head.

One of said alarms tore her from her work when she noticed Lisa hadn't shown up for afternoon tea, and Jean didn't think it twice: she stepped out of her office to go for Lisa herself. However, before she could reach the library door, Amber came into the headquarters and intercepted Jean, extremely worried.

—Master Jean!— Amber cried out. —We need help… I… this time I just can't wake Fischl up, and Oz is fading away because the prisms don't seem to work— she blurted out, speaking quickly. —And Bennett said he's been helping Andrius keep Razor fed, but now they can't wake him up either, and if they don't…

Jean put her hands on Amber's shoulders and looked into her eyes trying to calm her down.

—I understand, Amber, but breath— she said. —I'm also concerned about this, so please go for Albedo and Sucrose, maybe they can help. They may know how to keep them healthy even if they won't wake up to eat— Jean suggested, remembering some of Lisa's suggestions about the subject.

Amber nodded and, as soon as Jean released her, took a deep breath. She watched Jean walk into the library while wondering where to look for the alchemists first, pacing back and forth. But before she could do anything, she noticed Jean had frozen right in front of Lisa's desk,

where the witch seemed to had passed out, and simultaneously heard Klee shouting and walking her way.

—Miss Lisa!— the little girl cried, and Jean looked back at the door.

As soon as she made eye contact with the outrider, she shook her head and Amber swiftly stopped Klee on her way to the library. It didn't take long to convince the little girl to accompany her to find her brother Albedo, and soon they were gone.

Minutes later, Jean walked out of the library carrying Lisa in her arms, her hat left on the desk enough of a message for anyone who walked in.

City of Mondstadt, Favonius Cathedral, afternoon :

Jean arrived at the Cathedral breathless, the situation so noticeably dire that the doors were opened for her as soon as she was seen, and the nuns didn't lose a second before taking her to Barbara. Without asking questions, they provided one of their pallets for medical attention, and then left the sisters alone.

—She's still alive, just… very deeply asleep— Barbara assured Jean. —I'm surprised she lasted this long.

Jean looked at Barbara, confused and speechless for a second.

—What exactly do you mean by that?— Jean uttered.

—Ah- well… eh… I presume she had been using some sort of potion to have enough energy at least for half a day— Barbara explained. She lowered her sight before adding —She once sent Noelle with a batch of potions, asking if they were safe for Fischl and Razor. She gave Noelle a very specific description of the components, effects, and how they worked on her system. Unfortunately, I realized they would probably damage the nervous system of any child, and it was especially dangerous for Razor as he's even less used to synthetic potions like those.

—So she was… that's why she woke up so late but then had plenty of energy— Jean realized.

—Yes— Barbara nodded. —But clearly, even the power of the potion isn't enough now; and it was already dangerous as it was so… I'm sorry, sister, but you should let her sleep.

Jean took Lisa's left hand between hers and kept silent for a moment.

Finally, she asked —If I leave her here, can you keep her alive even if she doesn't wake up for days?—. Barbara nodded and Jean sighed. —Then I'll have the Knights bring Fischl and Razor too— she added. Barbara accepted, but seemed a bit confused with how she connected the subjects, so Jean explained —She clearly cared more for them than for herself, so making sure they are well taken care of is the only thing I can do for her now.

Hours later, the three were in pallets arranged in the same room and Barbara instructed the nuns how and when to attend them. Jean stayed a couple more hours next to Lisa, she didn't want to leave as she felt she was abandoning her.

—Sister?— Barbara called her from the door. —It's getting late, you should leave and rest.

—I… don't want to.

Barbara carefully approached her while asking —What do you want?

—I want her to wake up, I want all of them to wake up— she let out, her voice barely audible. —At this point, I don't give a damn about their electro power, just… why? Why take them away from us?— she continued, rage slowly building on her. —It makes no sense! And it is *not fair* !— she continued, almost shouting the last part.

Barbara placed her hands on her shoulders and tried to calm her down. Jean was trembling, and moments later, she was sobbing.

—Sister… they will be fine— she said, before finally daring to hug her. —They will be fine — she repeated. —We will keep them safe.

Even Barbara was silently crying after that, and none of them noticed the sudden shine of anemo power that sipped into the room and surrounded Lisa, Fischl, and Razor. They were still sound asleep but now their breathing was deeper.

City of Mondstadt, Favonius Headquarters, morning :

The news about the kids and Lisa being awake but extremely weak had given Jean enough strength to keep doing her work; the feeling of absolute defeat had receded a little, and she couldn't abandon the city, if anything she wanted to preserve Mondstadt for them. That morning she had arrived earlier than ever, took it upon herself to at least open the library, and then let the staff handle the administration, and when she found Lisa's hat there, it took her a minute too long to snap out of the nostalgic trance.

Finally, she was now sitting on her desk, Lisa's stuff, recovered from the library, were laying on the large table, and her focus was solely on finishing all the reports due. A knock on the door announced the expected arrival of Venti, who had informed he'd visit her as soon as he could.

—Good morning, Master Jean— he greeted her. His eyes laid almost instantly on the table with Lisa's things and it took him a second to recover himself. —Sorry for earlier, but I wanted to stop by the cathedral before coming to see you.

—Ah… I see— Jean answered. It was obvious she was working with little interest, mostly out of muscle memory, focused her mind but absent her heart. —What was the update you wanted to give me.

—I… well, I'll try to be concise— he began. —I'm still unable to speak with Baal, she is simply unwilling to give me even a minute of her time, so it's all on Lumine now. But, about that, I believe she has made some progress, from what I could gather. I'm surprised she hasn't written to you yet, maybe it's just delayed— he continued, clearly unable to be concise.

—Please, focus on the subject.

—Right, excuse me— he apologized. —The other thing was… I suppose you didn't notice but, I've been trying to extend their time— he told her, lowering his voice. —I know I can't do much, and I understand your frustration, I've heard you; but, to be honest, I'm afraid miss Lisa isn't entirely wrong. I, being a god, care for you… but have little power to help. While my world, the world of the gods, can do anything and everything, but never really put much effort into helping humanity.

—Venti, that wasn't…

—No, it's fine, Master Jean— he interrupted her, gently smiling. —Come to think of it… when I wanted to help, I never could, I've always had little power. And even now, the best I can do is provide assistance. Probably my assistance would be necessary even for other gods to properly solve something, but I'm nothing like Morax. He could argue with miss Lisa a bit more, but in the end, even he admits humans needn't have godly help.

—Venti, listen. If you really can give them more time, then that's enough— Jean stated. —Right now, I can and will appreciate any form of help, because our human capabilities have been surpassed, and even potions and magic don't have enough power. You want to believe you don't have enough power to help us? I won't force you to think otherwise, but even if you can't reverse the Electro Archon's spell, giving them more time is more than what we can do.

Venti nodded, more sure than earlier, somehow fueled by Jean's words. There was a fire in her eyes; the Grand Master wasn't giving up, not yet.

The door of the office suddenly burst open and Amber rushed in without waiting for an invitation, yelling —She found it! Lumine has the solution!

Jean and Venti stared at her in confusion for a second before she said —Outrider, calm down, and please explain yourself.

—I-I'm so sorry, yes— she apologized and took out a letter. —It's a little confusing but basically…— she began, looking through the letter to remind herself of everything she had to say. —She couldn't manage to convince the archon to undo her spell. And even knowing the consequences it will have wouldn't convince her. She only cared about her power, whether humans deserved it, and kept saying her doings were eternal.

—That's less than encouraging, Outrider— Venti told her, with a light-hearted tone but somehow worried.

—But Lumine found a way around it!— she replied, excited. —She told the archon that, if her will is eternal, then she herself went against that when she took away the electro power

she had given out. So, Lumine challenged her to return the electro power, and prove her power was superior— Amber explained. —When she said that, being the only electro user, she wasn't the most powerful one because there was no one to compare to, it apparently did the trick. The catchy part is, because the archon refused to undo anything else, especially now that she had realized she went against her own philosophy, she gave Lumine permission to perform the counter-spell, and once she has gathered all she needs, she will be allowed into the same place where the archon did the spell so that the counter-spell reaches all of Teyvat too.

—That's… that means…— Jean began to say, but couldn't find the words.

—We just need to give Lumine enough time— Venti stated.

—I'll write back to her, maybe she can tell us how much time she needs— Amber decided.

—Yes, please, do that. We should probably find Albedo to let him know about this— Jean replied.

Some hours later, Jean returned to her office after discussing with Albedo the possible outcomes of Lumine's solution. She had also stopped by the cathedral on her way back, Venti stayed there and she left once she saw Lisa open her eyes at least a moment.

She sighed and walked to her desk, she still had work to do. But Lisa's things on the table called her attention. Between her stuff, she had recovered a notebook and several empty vials she decided to take back home, but only now it had occurred to her that those could be the potion she had been using, according to Barbara. So she took a seat on the table and checked the vials for labels revealing their content.

—Is this even a word?— she muttered when she found only symbols inscribed on the labels. But there was also the notebook, which may have a glossary for the symbols. —Ah, this here…— she noticed. The notebook had few pages written, Lisa may have begun it exclusively for her research on the potion as there were notes on the components, the different variants, and the effectiveness. —The symbols are references to the components… and this…— she thought aloud until she began reading Lisa's notes about her daily progress. —"It seems to be just as effective as the natural version, but this variant can counter the metaphysical discordances". The what?— Jean could barely understand what Lisa meant, but couldn't stop reading. —"It lasts barely half a day, but at least this version gives enough energy to be focused, move around, and my reflexes seem unaltered", wait, this is from the day she wanted to prove to me she could blink away from danger. It was… a test? —"If it allows me to keep up with Jean, this must be the most powerful version yet"— she kept on reading. —"Apparently my modified potions are even stronger than I thought, meaning I should already be knocked out the whole day. I would have preferred it to be safe for the kids, but if it will keep me awake, then I can keep looking for a safer alternative". She was… she was making this and testing it on herself… for them? Why didn't she say something or ask for help? Eh? This one is the last note: "Even this stronger version is losing it's effectiveness. Maybe I should let Jean know about this, but I may not last enough to explain everything. On the subject of making this version more powerful maybe I could add some…". Oh, she fainted here— Jean noted, since the word "some" was poorly scribbled and the ink left a shaky trail after it.

Jean closed the notebook, neatly tidied up all the vials next to it, and finally went to her desk. She had never doubted Lisa's diligence, but finding out how much she pushed herself, fighting Baal's spell, shocked Jean. The witch had done literally everything in her power for this, and once again, now they could only wait. However, maybe there was something else she could do; perhaps, once they knew what Lumine needed for the counter-spell, she could send someone with the materials.

Somewhere in Inazuma, an open field, night :

Lumine was laying on the grass, looking up to the starry sky, trying to find some peace of mind. The last few days she had been running around searching for the rarest components for the counter-spell Baal gave her, and the previous day, a messenger bird from Liyue had delivered her a letter from the Grand Master, informing her she was sending part of the materials Lumine had talked about in her letter. Clearly, the most common ones, which Lumine still didn't have, and since the letter was sent from Liyue, whoever had been sent could be expected between that day and the next one. That was why Lumine had decided to make camp on the outskirts of Inazuma, the closest to Liyue, relatively speaking. But, that way, they wouldn't have to worry about the restrictions.

—Hey! Paimon sees someone coming!— Paimon shouted, suddenly interrupting Lumine's meditation.

She got up and followed where Paimon pointed. Almost instantly she recognized her by the clothes. Captain Eula approached quickly, carrying a backpack.

—Honorary Knight— she greeted her. —Good night, I bring you supplies from the Acting Grand Master— she announced.

—Thank you, Eula— she answered. —With this, I have everything needed.

—Wait… Paimon wonders… why were you sent to bring this?— Paimon suddenly interrupted.

—The Grand Master told me to send the fastest from my troupe, and that is me— she replied.

—And how did you come from Liyue to Inazuma? Even on a boat, this was faster than expected— Lumine questioned her.

—I didn't take a boat, I made an ice bridge here— she answered.

Paimon held her head and said —Paimon should have expected it, just like Kaeya.

—Resourcefulness is a necessary trait for a good knight— she argued.

—So you *do* care about the Knights— Lumine tested her.

—As I said to the Grand Master—, she quickly replied, —I can't let the Knights be destroyed before I can get my vengeance.

—But there are few electro users in Mondstadt in general, and only Lisa is part of the Knights— Lumine reflected.

—You'd be surprised, they've been too reliant on her— she simply answered.

—And you haven't?

—I- *Ahem*, I have mostly done my job alone or with my troupe. If anyone from my troupe made use of her services to complete our missions, that's not on me— Eula argued.

—Paimon heard that, when you're back in the city, you always have tea with Master Jean and Lisa— Paimon interrupted. —Would you ever skip tea?

Eula looked at Paimon in disbelief, and Lumine quickly added —She's right. We know Master Jean wouldn't stop even for tea if Lisa didn't insist on it.

She coughed and looked away before replying —Maybe it can be said that little recreation, to make sure we don't overwork ourselves, is actually… her doing… But it doesn't mean I rely on her.

Lumine held a giggle and thanked Eula. They calculated that by the time Eula would be back in the city, she should be performing the spell, so they should see the effects soon.

—This will finish soon, I promise— Lumine stated. She looked down at the backpack and added —They will all be fine. Please let them know in Liyue too.

Eula nodded once before running back the way she came.

City of Mondstadt, Favonius Cathedral, noon :

That morning, Captain Eula had arrived extremely exhausted, asking to speak urgently with Master Jean. Kaeya made sure no one got in her way, and when they were in Jean's office, she let them know they should be expecting the effects of the counter-spell that same day. Jean automatically dismissed Eula so she could rest, and sent Kaeya to find Albedo; she ordered for him to go to the cathedral, and Kaeya said she should go too; after getting Albedo, he could cover for her.

Now, she was sitting next to Lisa, gently holding her right hand, while Albedo checked the kids, expecting to see signs of the counter-spell any second.

—What… what happens if it's already too late?— Jean suddenly asked.

Albedo raised his sight, interrupting his pondering, and calmly answered —There's no reason to think it's too late. They still show signs of being alive, Lumine is doing the spell today, according to what she told captain Eula, and the magic will have to resonate in all nations as the spells set by the ambassadors haven't been removed.

—We don’t know if Lumine was actually able to do it, or if the archon kept her word. Maybe she was detained, maybe she’s being stalled on purpose to keep her from doing it on time, maybe…

—Master Jean— Albedo interrupted her. —Why the sudden negativity?

Jean opened her mouth to speak but couldn’t say a word. She lowered her head and held Lisa’s hand tighter. Albedo didn’t need an answer, it was clear: her worst fears were manifesting in her mind mercilessly.

He watched her slowly relax her posture as the hours passed by. It was already nighttime when Jean rested her head next to Lisa’s refusing to let go of her hand. He kept checking on the kids every half an hour, but they remained the same. And suddenly, Jean woke up abruptly, scared.

Albedo didn’t pay attention at first, she hadn’t slept more than a few minutes, but then he noticed she was staring at Lisa with a terrified expression. He had just checked the kids about twenty minutes earlier, there couldn’t have been any notorious changes, yet reality proved him wrong. They were suddenly pale as paper, and when he checked, their body temperature was dropping fast.

—They need more time— he stated.

—How? What can we do?— she asked, desperation slowly taking over her.

—Trust me, Grand Master. Please— he asked.

—What will you do, Albedo?

—Hopefully some… extra life for them.

Jean didn’t even want to know what that meant. Her desperation was enough to let him do absolutely anything to ensure they lived. And so, she nodded and kept her focus on Lisa. She decided, if she didn’t see whatever Albedo was doing, she wouldn’t feel the need to ask any questions.

City of Mondstadt, outside Favonius Cathedral, late night :

Amber, Bennett, and Mona were standing right outside the entrance to the cathedral. They wouldn’t dare enter, not yet, but their anxiety was such, they kept nagging Mona to check her astrolabe.

—It’s been too long, please, please! Tell us something!— Amber insisted.

—Maybe I shouldn’t have come, it’s my bad luck again, isn’t it?— Bennett commented.

—Stop it, you two. I will check if I feel it’s necessary. And you, if you think you give everyone bad luck, why come?— Mona suddenly replied.

—I didn’t want to come, I was… I stayed with Andrius and the wolves today, then Diona stopped by when she went to Wolvendom to gather ingredients, and she said that, if we wanted to know how Razor was doing, maybe I should come to see. And Andrius asked me to get him news about Razor, but now I don’t want to enter… what if we bother them?— Bennett explained, talking fast and nervously.

Mona sighed and took out her astrolabe.

—Fine, give me a moment, if you leave at least you won’t head back without anything to tell Andrius— she finally accepted. But it wasn't long before she realized the situation was actually worse than expected. —I… actually… maybe you should… you know what?— she stammered a bit before clearing her throat to speak a full sentence. —Maybe we should go and take a seat— she muttered, walking towards one of the stone benches in front of the cathedral.

—What happened?— Amber asked.

—The counter-spell doesn’t appear to have taken effect yet— she began. —And, what I can see here… I’ll just say their lives seem to be waning too.

—But… but they are still alive, right?— Bennett asked.

—They still have time for the spell, don’t they?— Amber insisted.

—Well, something seems to be giving them life at almost the same speed it scapes from them, and as long as that happens, they may have enough time— Mona replied. —However, I have no idea what this is. What is giving them life?

Amber shook her head and stated —It doesn’t matter. If it gives them time, we can look into that later.

Before anyone could say another word, the gates of the cathedral opened and Barbara came out and found them seated barely a few meters away.

—Something is happening, please come— she asked, apparently referring to Mona, but all of them followed her in.

City of Mondstadt, Favonius Cathedral, midnight :

Jean still refused to look at Albedo. Instead, she had taken out the wooden box with Lisa’s vision and placed it open right next to her. It was still dull, yet Jean kept her eyes on it, expecting it to light up again.

The room was unnaturally lit up, something was shining brightly, but she ignored it. Her sight fixed on the vision.

—Come on, just activate again— she muttered. —Ah… Archons, please— she sighed.

Her sight became blurred with tears, but she didn't want to close her eyes, she needed to see the vision light up. And for a second, she could have sworn there was, in fact, a faint light within it. She quickly brushed her eyes and stared at the vision in awe. Jean recognized the spiral within Lisa's vision. It was back.

She looked at the witch and cupped her face with both hands, hoping to feel her warmth again. And the next moment, when the shine of the vision called her attention back, she finally let out a relieved laugh.

—They are back, the visions are back!— she exclaimed, crying with joy. The room got darker the next moment and she heard Albedo panting. When she looked back, the alchemist seemed out of breath, his hands on his legs as he couldn't stand straight. —Thank you, Master Alchemist. Please rest, I'll handle the rest.

He only nodded and let himself fall against the wall. Jean stood up, let out a long breath, and went to open the door, only to find her sister, along with Mona, Amber, and Bennett.

—What happened? What was all that light?— Barbara asked preocupied.

—Please, don't worry. It worked. The visions reactivated— she announced.

The relief in Bennett and Amber's expression was evident. Mona was more shocked than relieved at first, but then let out a smile and sighed. Barbara couldn't believe it and wanted to see them, so Jean asked the girls to lend her a hand to help them, and asked Bennett to assist Albedo. She promised he could come back to take Razor to Wolvendom as soon as he could leave the bed.

—This is… It really worked— Mona sighed. —I still can't believe it even happened in the first place but… Ah, never mind. I better not question a good outcome— she decided.

Jean and Mona were seated at each side of Lisa, while Barbara finished checking Razor's vital signs and Amber retrieved some supplies from the cathedral's storeroom. Once she was back, they prepared a batch of food and water to give them as soon as they woke up.

Around dawn, Razor began moving, trying to wake up. Shortly after, Fischl and Lisa seemed to be almost awake too. Jean was left to attend Lisa on her own while Barbara, Amber, and Mona helped the kids.

—Welcome back— Jean whispered. Lisa could listen to her, but somehow it was even difficult for her to smile at that. —Take it easy for now, alright? I'll help you sit and you can eat a little— she offered. Moments later, Lisa was given food and water and could barely keep herself from gulping it all in one go. —That's better— Jean sighed.

—I… I'm sorry, Jean— Lisa finally said, her voice slightly raspy. —I must have worried you.

Jean sighed and kissed her forehead before saying —Yes, but you would have worried me regardless, even if I knew about the potions… And, I read your notes, I know you wanted to tell me.

Lisa finally felt strong enough to move and raised her left hand to cup Jean's cheek.

—I'm so glad it worked— she let out.

Jean didn't reply, just closed the distance and kissed her. She hadn't felt this much joy in a long time. They were all safe, already laughing and chatting behind her. Her mind could finally rest, she didn't need to think or worry anymore, just enjoy their presence, almost back to normal already.

Chapter End Notes

Epilogue unlocked

Epilogue: Her Only Wish.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

City of Mondstadt, Market District, almost noon :

The city was livelier than ever. Most of the knights were carrying stuff from the market to the plaza in front of the cathedral, while Good Hunter, Angel's Share, and Cat's Tail were all providing food and drinks waiting to be taken to the plaza too.

Lisa walked by, wearing an impeccable new outfit similar to her usual garments but of white and lilac fabric, decorated with blue embroidery. Those who passed her by waved a hand at her, but mostly the witch was strolling through the market district unbothered.

—Miss Lisa!— Paimon's voice suddenly called.

—Oh, Cutie you're back— she noticed.

—And right on time, apparently— Lumine replied, approaching. —We didn't miss it, right.

Lisa giggled and assured her —No, no. Everything is still being prepared, even if it's almost time.

—Paimon thinks that dress suits you— she noticed.

—Oh, well, thank you, Paimon— Lisa replied with a smile. —You should see Jean— she added with a mischievous look. —Her suit is attracting all looks, I haven't seen her so embarrassed in public before.

—And it doesn't bother you?— Lumine asked.

—Why would it? Everyone finally acknowledges how handsome she is, I'm thrilled— she laughed.

—You're just enjoying how embarrassed she is.

Lisa couldn't hold back her laugh.

—Fine! Yes, I adore her expression when she's embarrassed— she admitted.

—Master?— Razor's voice called from behind Lumine. He was wearing formal clothes, possibly lent to him by Bennett's fathers, and carried a small bouquet between his hands. —This… for Purple teacher— he said, offering her the bouquet.

She took it and noticed the mix of dandelions and cecilias, apparently gathered by him.

—Oh, thank you, little Wolfie— she said, caressing his head with one hand while holding the bouquet with the other. —I suggest you, kids, only join us for the food— she then said, laughing a bit. —The ceremony will probably be a bit boring.

—No— Razor replied, shaking his head. —I want to go.

—Oh, how adorable— she muttered, covering her mouth. —Well, in that case… Can I ask you, Cutie, to keep him company? And walk with him to the cathedral?

—No problem— Paimon replied happily.

—On the way, I can show you the cool electro power I got in Inazuma— Lumine told him.

—Yes, I want to see— he nodded.

Lisa hummed and told her —I'm interested in that too. Perhaps you won't mind performing a few tests later, so I can take proper notes.

—Of course— Lumine laughed.

They decided to head to the cathedral after that, so they wouldn't have to run there when it was about to begin. However, Lisa didn't seem hurried at all. On the contrary, it was like she had all the time in the world; and maybe she did.

—It's really happening…— she whispered, closing her eyes for a moment. Yet, when she heard Jean's voice nearby behind her, she looked around, trying to find where she was. —Not stopping for a moment, eh? Always the diligent Grand Master— she mumbled with a small smile.

A second later, Jean was rushing across the market; she ran past the fountain, following a cat, apparently, and Lisa had to keep herself from bursting out laughing. Instead, she followed Jean and the cat with her sight and blinked. When she appeared right in the cat's path, it stopped suddenly and Jean caught it.

—Gotcha!— Jean shouted. —Thanks for the assist, Lisa— she said, walking towards the witch with the cat between her arms.

—Are you trying to ruin your suit before the wedding?— Lisa told her off teasingly. —Ah… Maybe you shouldn't have changed until the ceremony's about to start— she commented.

—What? No, actually it should begin any moment now!— Jean responded. —I was looking for you when this little rascal ran past, so I thought I could well help out until I found you.

—I think *I* found *you*, Love— Lisa mocked her.

They both began walking towards the plaza in companionable silence. Lisa subtly checked Jean's suit for any stains, but fortunately, it just had some cat hair. However, as her jacket is white and her shirt dark blue, she would have to make sure to clean her up once they handed the cat back to Margaret.

City of Mondstadt, Favonius Cathedral, noon :

—Ah…— Jean sighed. —This was the single most stressful month ever— she let out, once she and Lisa found themselves alone in a room of the cathedral, waiting for the ceremony to start.

—Really? Worse than the Stormterror's incidents?— Lisa asked her.

—Are you serious? Of course!— Jean replied, while the witch approached to hug her waist. —You could say the preparations for today are taking as much manpower as the repairs after Dvalin's attacks, so yes.

Lisa laughed daintily and released Jean, tidying her belt. She stared at it for a moment, the golden emblem of the Knights was actually a perfect compliment for her suit. Jean looked stunning on it.

—You look wonderful today, you know?— Lisa let out.

—Pretty much like you— Jean answered before kissing her.

Suddenly Lisa remembered Razor's bouquet and used her magic to produce it on her hand.

—I think, this would look nicely here— the witch said as she embedded it into a pocket on Jean's jacket. —Razor collected it— she told her.

Jean giggled and commented —That kid adores you.

Lisa smiled and hooked her arm around Jean's. They looked at each other a moment before walking out.

City of Mondstad, Anemo Archon Statue Plaza, afternoon :

Tables and chairs were placed around the plaza, allowing everyone to either mingle or take a seat and enjoy food and drink of their choice. All kinds of food had been served, meaty dishes, varied salads, pizza, and even bowls of soup. Likewise, there was either wine and cocktails or fruit juice and non-alcoholic mixes to choose from, carefully watched by Diona to make sure kids wouldn't grab alcohol, and adults wouldn't get drunk.

—Miss Lisa!— Amber called, approaching Jean and the witch. —Oh, it should be missus Lisa? Maybe, madam Lisa?— she tried to correct herself.

Lisa had to cover her mouth and make a conscious effort to gulp down her drink before she could stop Amber, while Jean held her tongue, trying not to laugh.

—Amber, Dear… just stick to "miss Lisa", forget the titles— she told her.

—Ah- eh… sorry, I'll do that— she apologized. —I just wanted to officially congratulate you both— she said with a bright smile. —And such a happy event will probably help us recover from all the… turbulent… month we just had— she added, scratching the back of her neck nervously.

—I hope so— Jean admitted. —Oh… and speaking about it… have you two seen the Honorary Knight? Apparently, she controls electro now that she reversed the Archon's spell — she told them.

—I haven't seen her power yet but I asked her to give me some time to take notes on it while she performs a few tests— Lisa answered, her eyes almost shining.

—Please, please. Don't take advantage of her diligence— Jean replied.

—Oh, come on. I'd never ask Lumine for such a favor without proper compensation.

—Her power is amazing! I can't blame miss Lisa for wanting to study it— Amber laughed.

That same moment, Fischl approached behind the girl, Oz flying at her side.

—Afternoon, oh mighty gladiator currently overseeing this nation, and magus-custodian of books, gatekeeper of universal knowledge— she said, referring first to Jean, and then to Lisa. The witch giggled while Jean and Amber looked at each other without commenting. —On this most joyous occasion, one extends you one's best wishes for a rewarding forthcoming life in mutual company.

—Mein Fräulein hopes you have a happy future together— Oz translated.

Jean let out a smile and Lisa laughed wholeheartedly.

—Thank you both, Dears. I hope you're feeling better— the witch answered.

—Your assistance certainly alleviated my situation, thank you— Oz replied.

—Ma-maybe we should let them enjoy their party now— Amber interrupted. —Come, Fischl, you *have* to try these hashbrowns— she said before dragging the girl with her.

Lisa giggled when Jean looked back at her in confusion.

—That was… interesting— she finally said.

—Oh, Dear! You should hear how she asks for her books— Lisa laughed. —But the least I can do is humor her a bit, don't you think? No one takes care of those books more than her.

—No wonder she's your favorite— Jean replied, mockingly.

—Ah, don't you dare, Jean Gunnhildr!— Lisa retorted, letting go of her glass, which would have fallen without her magic to keep it floating; the witch caught Jean's wrists and pulled her close. She whispered into her ear —I'll have to teach you a lesson later.

Jean blushed intensely and looked away when Lisa let go of her.

—That…— she coughed, still avoiding the witch’s eyes. —That sounds good, actually.

Lisa's sly expression when Jean looked back only worsened her blush, especially when the witch replied, with a lowered tone, —Oh, does it? Then why are you still so shy around your wife, Acting Grand Master?

Lisa wrapped Jean's waist and kissed her without letting her answer. A loud cheer began and everyone in the plaza applauded. When they parted, even Lisa was red with embarrassment.

The celebration continued until later, even past midnight, and they had time to check on everyone who helped them the past month, eager to share their views about the events. And before the newlyweds could retire, a certain Gunnhildr Clan member shyly showed up; it was so unexpected that Jean preferred to talk to her alone.

The witch observed the reunion from a distance, concealed between the shadows, just far enough from every street light and lantern. Her emotions were in conflict at first, but she quickly calmed down. She had just married the one person for whom she'd go to Mare Jivari without a second thought, nothing could possibly disturb her now. She remembered what she told Jean, how the world of the gods didn't intend to care for them, and now, she was sure she didn't need them either. She'd welcome their care and concern, of course, but she only truly needed that stubborn Grand Master, heir to the Gunnhildr Clan who only wished to stay by her side, to care for her. That was Lisa's only wish.

Chapter End Notes

Quest finished.

Huge thanks to everyone who took the time to read through that. I recognize it has a bit too much unnecessary nerdiness, but I felt like it would build Lisa's character better. Also, to anyone who recognized, for instance, what Lisa was reading at the beginning of Act 2, congratulations, we have the same level of "nerd", enjoy the deeper understanding.

And to conclude this notes: You may have noticed I barely spoke of Liyue, which, in turn, gives anyone who wishes to write a beigguang or a ganking, or just any Liyue couple, within this universe. And once Inazuma is out, even a fic a bit more accurate or taking place there? The possibilities are many and I want you all to know this universe is now public if you'd like to use the premise of the waned electro visions.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!